

PLUS...
BANGER RACING IN NZ
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THE ULTIMATE BRITISH ASIAN?
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... AND MORE!

JOANNE MCNALLY HITS BALLER STATUS

ralph

610 / \$10.95 ISSUE 17 SPRING 2020



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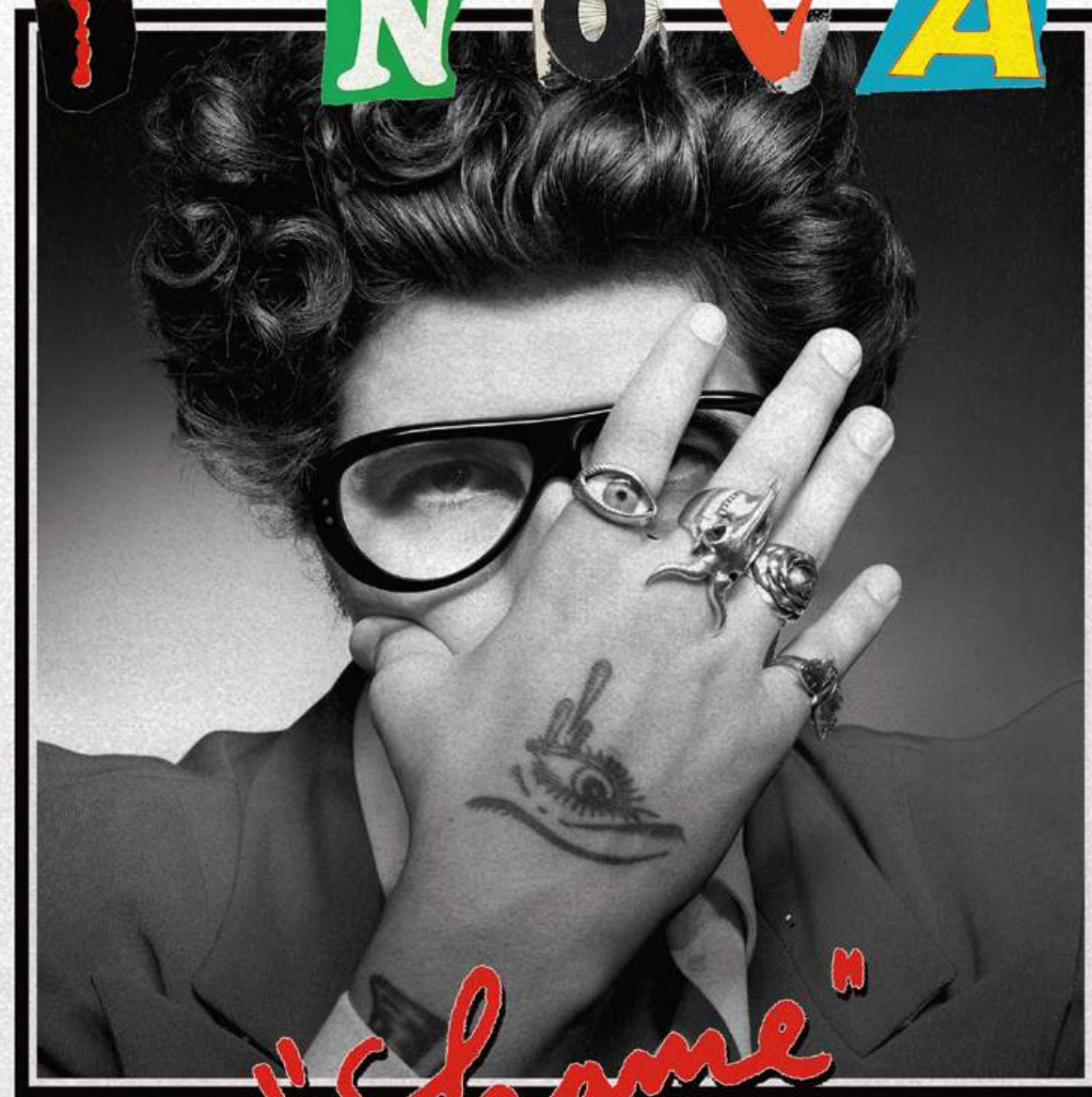
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STOLEN NOVA



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PHOTO BY MADISON BLAIR

Head of TV



Illustration by T. Wesley Snead

Watch TV's top talents wilt under the microphone of the toughest interviewer in town...



Have you ever been on TV?

What TV show are you watching right now?

What's the best TV show ever?

Who is your favourite TV character of all time?

What show is your guilty pleasure?

[youtube.com/@Ralph-World](https://www.youtube.com/@Ralph-World)

What TV show would delete from existence?

What TV show has the best theme tune?

What TV show did you watch as a kid?

What TV moment can you never forget?





Your
hair
is not
crap



DEEP MOISTURISING
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Editor's Letter

Hello!

I was recently talking to some other magazine makers about writing the dreaded Editor's Letter. Why do they end up as just another list of what's in the magazine? We've already done that on the cover and there's a contents page literally right after it. Do readers even read them?

So, if you are reading this, thanks. Instead of going on about what's in this issue, I'd like to say that one of the things I love most about this magazine is everything in *Ralph* celebrates people doing fun stuff. So when agents, publicists and journalists contact us about putting their clients on the cover or pitching something for the magazine, the one thing we always need to know is:

"Is it fun? Are they funny?"

Ralph is a home for weird, wonderful and funny stuff – really interesting stories that aren't "tailored to your tastes". We want you to discover stuff, laugh, and then get on with doing whatever it is you do.

To paraphrase the criminally under-listened Hall & Oates song...

[long sax intro]... *It's a laugh (Whoo ooh ooh ooh)*
What a laugh (Whoo ooh ooh ooh)
It's so stupid, I gotta laugh!

Go on now, go and read the contents page

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Jacob Alon

The Ultimate British Asian?

Hot, Wet and Noisy

Drinking Games

Bird Is The Word

Straight From The Horse's Mouth

Bored? Listen to This

Dressing and Impressing

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Mentally Feral, Physically Groomed

Sounds Of The City

Max's Gav's Dispatches

You Gotta Be Yolking

Max Headroom Has a Virus

Don't Google This

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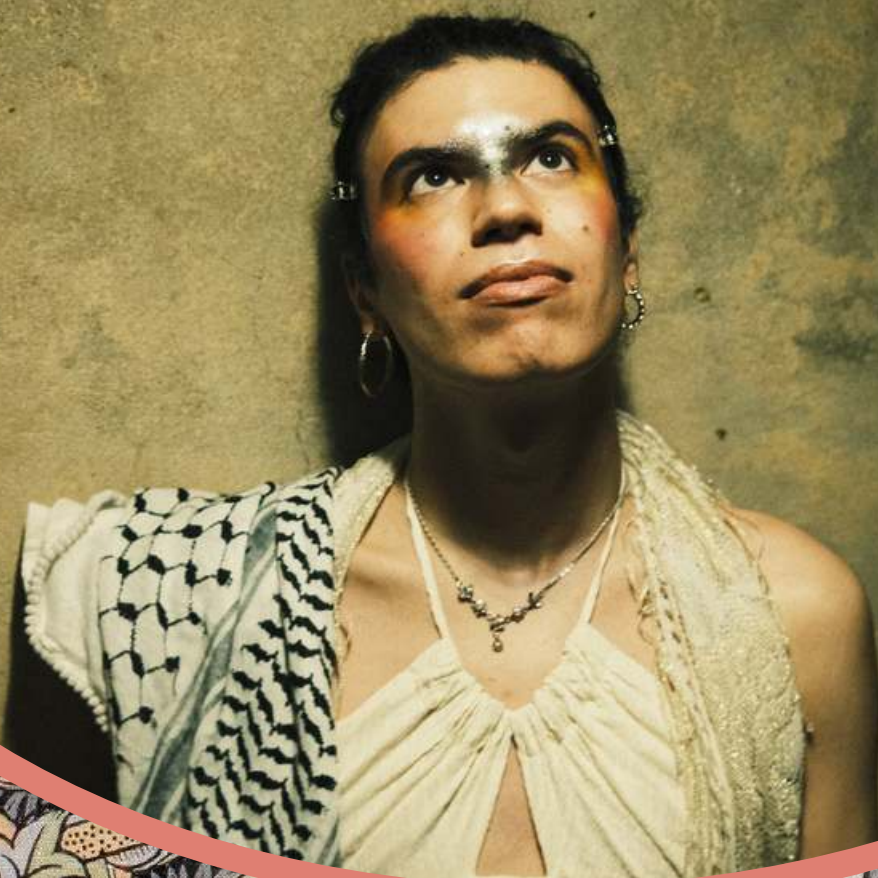
JACOB ALON

Are they the future of music and goths?

Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by Zachariah Mahrouche

Jacob Alon is a sensation. The 25-year-old Scottish songwriter's ethereal sound has seen them conquer dizzying heights as their debut album *In Limerance* practically haunted all of last summer. Since then they have won BBC Introducing Artist of the Year 2025, Brit's Critic's Choice 2026, been nominated for a Mercury Prize and performed on the prestigious BBC Jools Holland, and Graham Norton shows, and toured across the world. We sat down with them to ask some extremely important, and very pressing questions.

“I woke up completely on my own, freezing cold in this abandoned mill where the walls were falling in.”



You are the Brits Critics' Choice winner this year. In honour of Mel C's iconic 1997 call out of Liam Gallagher, who would you call out to fight at the podium and would you win?

Andrew (former Prince), and yes, of course I'd win.

'Don't Fall Asleep' is a single from your album *In Limerance*, what's the weirdest place you've ever fallen asleep?

In an abandoned paper mill. When I was 15, me and my friends were obsessed with finding really rough spots and sleeping there. We were there with these cool kids and we were getting really tired and fell asleep. At some point in the night, various people left at different times and then I woke up completely on my own at 11am, freezing cold in this abandoned mill where the walls were falling in.

If you could be a mythical creature, which one would you be?

I'd really like to be a fucking freaky ghoul. Like the ghoul of Pret on Seven Sisters Road. I'd hide in the free coffees they give out and terrorise people.

Your song ‘Fairy in a Bottle’ always brings to my mind the image of Fairy washing up liquid. What flavour of washing up liquid is the best?

I feel like lemon’s overdone. Lime is pretty intense. There’s the berry one? What are the other ones? [They proceed to open up their phone and scroll through washing up liquids on Google..]

OK, pomegranate...

Maybe like magnolia and sea bream [sic]...

Oh, honeysuckle and pink jasmine?

Lavender and rosemary, eucalyptus, pomegranate and grapefruit, that’s the one that I think I instinctively went for. Though I can’t have grapefruit now.

Let’s go honeysuckle and pink jasmine.

The word “limerance” sounds quite a lot like the word limerick, do you have a favourite one?

Dum dum dum dum dum dum dum dum
dum dum dum dum dum dum dum dum
dum dum dum dum dum
dum dum dum dum
dum dum dum dum fucking c*nts.

You’ve recently moved to Glasgow. You did live in Edinburgh. Which is better?

Glasgow. I used to not be able to choose, and then I grew the fuck up.

You were nominated for the *Mercury Prize*. Do you think it’s fair that Mercury is a planet but Pluto isn’t?

I think it’s fair enough. Some of Saturn’s moons are bigger than Pluto so it should consider itself lucky to be considered a dwarf planet.



Confess something to us?

I will tell you three but you have to redact all identifying features

OK, deal

I slagged off [REDACTED] to someone that works with him in a lift.
I got [REDACTED] for the first time.
I voted for [REDACTED].

Your series *Pillow Talk* explains each song on your album. What’s the weirdest thing you’ve said in bed?

You missed a spot.

If you were a goth, what flavour would you be?

Honeysuckle and pink jasmine. *ralph*

THE ULTIMATE BRITISH ASIAN?



No, it's not a new reality show. With more layers than a lasagne, Eshaan Akbar's one of the UK's most exciting comedians.

Words by Alexandra Haddow
Photos by Matt Stronge

“I speak four languages”



Eshaan Akbar can't be contained. That's what I've learnt through years of giggling with him and becoming friends over the best part of a decade, and even more so now that I've quizzed him excessively about his life, stand up, identity, politics, grief, class, and enjoying making things awkward for this magazine. Just a quick one then. His act uniquely talks about his mixed heritage growing up in Chadwell Heath as the son of a Bangladeshi paramedic father and Pakistani mother, as well as his cultural journey, brought up as a Muslim but no longer devout. After a career that includes working in the City, a speechwriter for HSBC and a Bollywood choreographer, Eshaan did his first gig aged 29, shortly after his mum unexpectedly passed away. In just over a decade he's taken numerous shows on national tours, appeared on Live At The Apollo twice (the second of which is shown this year), QI, Frankie Boyle's New World Order, opened for Micky Flanagan on his recent mammoth tour, and starred in Sex Education as Principal Lakani. He's been busy.

Alex: There's a thing that you said to me the other day which blew my mind – that you're the only British Asian comedian that we can think of who's bilingual. I'm sure there's some out there, but I'm talking about household names.

Eshaan: Not just bilingual, I speak four languages.

Alex: Alright chill out.

Eshaan: English was the fourth language I learnt to speak, and I wasn't allowed to speak English at home until I was seven years old. When I was seven, my mum heard me

speaking English for the first time with some friends of mine and I had an Ilford Rude Boy accent.

Alex: Which, for people reading this, you definitely don't have now...[Eshaan sounds like he reads the news on Radio 4 and could calm you down in any situation].

Eshaan: My mum was so angry she took me home and made me read her favourite book to her, which was *Wuthering Heights*. Out loud, like I was on the radio. [Ah...there we go then]. And then my accent... the pendulum landed here, in whatever this is, which is slightly east London, slightly posh.

Alex: How do you think your previous life in the City and the corporate world has influenced your comedy?

Eshaan: One thing I love about comedy, and I say this all the time, is it's the only art form that I can think of that rewards age and wisdom. You get better the older you get.

Alex: You're right, you want a rock star to be young and shagging and single.

Eshaan: Whereas I think the best comedians in the world are in their 50s and 60s. So it stands to reason when I started at 29 having been a banker, a government policy advisor, written for newspapers, been a speech writer. I experienced working with people from all different walks of life, but then also just going to university, going to private school and being Asian. By the time I started at 29, there was more stuff for me to draw from, but also my perspectives and the way I looked at the world was developed. And I think I'm just getting started.

Alex: You've got quite a unique perspective because now you're a person working in the arts after working in business. Would you describe yourself as a cross-class person? You went to a very good school but you got a scholarship, your parents were both immigrants, they lived here but you had this

private school education.

Eshaan: Yeah it was quite a fancy school, some footballer and film stars’ kids went there – it was TOWIE posh.

Alex: So not landed gentry.

Eshaan: No, definitely not. Recently I’ve got into this thing where I’m kind of calling myself the ultimate British Asian.

Alex: That’s a Channel 5 show isn’t it?

Eshaan: (Laughing) It should be! But going back to the Asian thing, pertinent to this question, you’re right, I’m a multilingual South Asian person. I used to be a Bollywood dance choreographer. I was trained in Indian classical singing.

Alex: You’re Nessa from Gavin and Stacey, you’ve lived a million lives!

Eshaan: I’m brown Nessa! So the Asian bit of me is really deeply rooted, and a big part of who I am. But the British part of me exists in both the private school world and the working class world. I was privately educated, I worked in banking in Mayfair.

Alex: You were mixing with the bad guys, and now you work in the arts.

Eshaan: Exactly! Then I wrote for, like, the *Guardian* and the *Times*. Like, I am basically, if you didn’t know my name and you just heard my voice, and heard about my career, you’d think I was a middle class white guy.

Alex: Surprise!

Eshaan: So over the next few years, I’m really trying to work on how I represent those two things. How they can co-exist? Because the criticism I get from Asians is I’m not Asian because I’m too British. I would say my audience is 80 to 85% white. And they’re cross classes. You’ve got the working class *Have A Word* lot, the middle class *QI*,

Mock The Week lot. The people who’ve seen me on panels at the *Guardian*. The 15% that remain... I would say there is a one to two percent crossover, even if it’s that of the Asian audience and, say Guz Khan or Tez Ilias’ audience. And in between is like, South Asian or non-European diaspora. So there’ll be some well-to-do Nigerians and some well-to-do Asians. The Asians that go to Dishoom.

Alex: Do you think that’s because you really talk about such a variety of topics in your stand-up? I would say you talk a lot about identity, but not necessarily race.

Eshaan: Yeah, I think that’s probably true. And I think that speaks to the fact that my life has been the way it’s been. It’s my identity that has both proven a barrier and provided an opportunity, rather than my race. My identity as a privately educated economics graduate allows me to do private banking. The race element only really came into play when they put me in front of wealthy Asian clients. Even with comedy it’s very hard to put me into a single box. Really hard. Which I think is a good thing, but other people say that when you’re looking for people for stuff on TV, that becomes a really tricky job. You know, the BBC have a diversity thing, right? They’ll go. ‘We’ve got to get an Asian man onto the show.’

Alex: I’m rolling my eyes because why does it have to be one? You could have three Asian guys on the show!

Eshaan: I know! That’s why I didn’t do *Strictly*. I was supposed to do it. There were lots of conversations three years ago, but then they were like, “we’ve got Krishnan Guru-Murthy”.

Alex: For fuck’s sake. It’s mad to me that they don’t think that’s a problematic thing to say.

Eshaan: But that’s the thing, the identity thing. The *Have A Word* lot saying, ‘You’re the whitest Asian guy I know.’ What they



“My aim is to make people who disagree with me laugh”



actually mean there is I don't sound how they think I should. But then there'll be Asians who, of course, call me a coconut quite often, then they'll say to me, 'Oh, you're really Asian, because you speak all the languages. You know all the songs'.

Alex: For a society who says we hate labels, we're constantly trying to categorise people. We're desperate to know who you are in a strict set of criteria.

Eshaan: Yeah everyone is like 'What box can I put you in?' The box is so wide, the box is British Asian, but it's as British and as Asian as you can get, really. I'm just as at home in the Wetherspoons in Chadwell Heath as I am at the Groucho Club, as I am in a shisha bar. They can all exist. I think people find that very difficult. 'How can you be the same person and authentically yourself in all these spaces?' I can! I am!

Alex: You're sometimes ambiguous politically as well.

Eshaan: Some of my contemporaries get pissed off with me because I'm seemingly not a bleeding heart left-wing liberal. Outwardly. Partly because as a comedian, I want people to come and see me for my comedy, not because they agree with me politically. My aim is to make people who disagree with me laugh.

Alex: You're right because obviously you're not a right-winger, or anywhere near that. But actually, you talk about loads of political stuff in a very roundabout way. You're not screaming and ranting about whoever.

Eshaan: One routine I do at the moment is about the amount of brown people who work at UK border force. And how much of a head fuck I find it. It's a comedy routine! But people don't know if I'm being genuine or not. I will also, and I do say this... I say that England is the best country in the world to be an ethnic minority. That should be a source of great pride for us. I wouldn't want

to be black in America. I wouldn't want to be Muslim in France. We've got our problems, but I will go out on record on stages and say, look, this is the best country in the world to be in the minority, and that should be to our credit. That should be something that Britain, as a truly pluralistic society that's welcoming, and has been as welcoming as Britain has been, for all its flaws, should be celebrated. And when I say that, people get pissed off. Because left-wing people, will be like what the fuck are you doing? Britain's awful to minorities. And then the Gammons are like, that's exactly the problem. They're taking over! So that's why I say I'm the ultimate British Asian, because I'm proud of both.

Alex: I think you like to provoke people on stage, in a good way, you say things, you do a joke, people react, and then they think about it. Is that something you like to do?

Eshaan: Oh, yeah, even in my personal relationships, I'm a wind up merchant. If I love you, I'm winding you the fuck up constantly. It's nice of me to hear that you feel like I do it on stage because I feel like I don't do that enough. I've always been a big believer that offence is taken not given. So with that in mind, with all the shit going on, I like provoking to the point where people really confront what it is they're actually annoyed about. If I'm saying something that's provoking a reaction in you, what is it you're angry about?

One of the best conversations I've had with someone was a woman who spoke to me after a gig and she told me she was on the Parsons Green tube bombing. She was on the train in that carriage when the bomb had gone off. This was about a year, maybe a year and a half after it happened. At that time I was doing lots of terrorism jokes, and she said to me, this was the first time she was able to A) laugh about terrorism, and B) that I had kind of arrested slightly, what was, by her admission, her deep dive into Islamophobia. She had got caught up in all the propaganda about Muslims and terrorism after it. And my

“I’m a wind up merchant. If I love you, I’m winding you up constantly”

stuff was provocatively ‘pro terrorism’ in the routine. So that’s an example of where that has worked. Inadvertently! That’s not what I set out to do. But that’s why I like doing it. I think making people come away and think, and question themselves is incredible.

Alex: This sounds like such a hack question, but opening for a British institution like Micky Flanagan at venues the size you did, were you nervous?

Eshaan: I’m just so glad that I’m here, I’ve had to face my own mortality. This sounds strange but I haven’t been nervous for anything since my mum passed away.

Alex: What you’re basically saying is, the worst thing that’s possibly happened to me has happened.

Eshaan: Yeah, pretty much. And like, you know, my life since then has made me not fear death, right? And there is something about not fearing the prospect of death that makes everything seem possible, sort of frees you in a way. Gigging at The O2, it’s a huge stage. There’s 18,000 people, you don’t want to fuck it up. But I’m there for a reason. Micky Flanagan would not stake his reputation by having me on that, of course, yeah, I could do it.

Alex: Where are your favourite places to gig in the UK?

Eshaan: Oh always places like Liverpool, Belfast, Glasgow... and what do they have in common? Why do I do well there?

Alex: Shipyards? Ports? Craic?

Eshaan: Working class communities share a similar sense of humour to immigrants because they’re both collectively scapegoated by the powerful. There’s always funny people in the audience and if you can out-funny them, they take you to their hearts.

Alex: Well, on that quite lovely emotional note, I have one more question for you: if you could pick one element of Asian culture that the Brits should adopt, and one element of British culture that you think Asians should work on more, what they would be? What can they learn from each other?

Eshaan: Asians are able to have a lot of fun sober. A LOT of fun sober. And there is a real depth and diversity of conversation, I’m mainly talking about Muslims. I’ve grown up my whole life in those households and some of the best parties I’ve been to have been those parties. Because there’s a lot of laughter, so there’s that. But it’s a similar thing in terms of what I would love for Asians to get, is the British sense of banter and fun. We’re able to take the piss out of each other in a way, I think sometimes with Asians, if you take the piss too much, it can turn violent and aggressive and disrespectful. But this is why I love Liverpool and Belfast – you can call someone a c*nt to their face on stage they’re laughing, like, “heeeey come on!” Whereas, I’ve been with Asians who said that and they’ve gone, “that’s incredibly rude and disrespectful”. It’s weirdly two sides of the same coin. Which is apt!



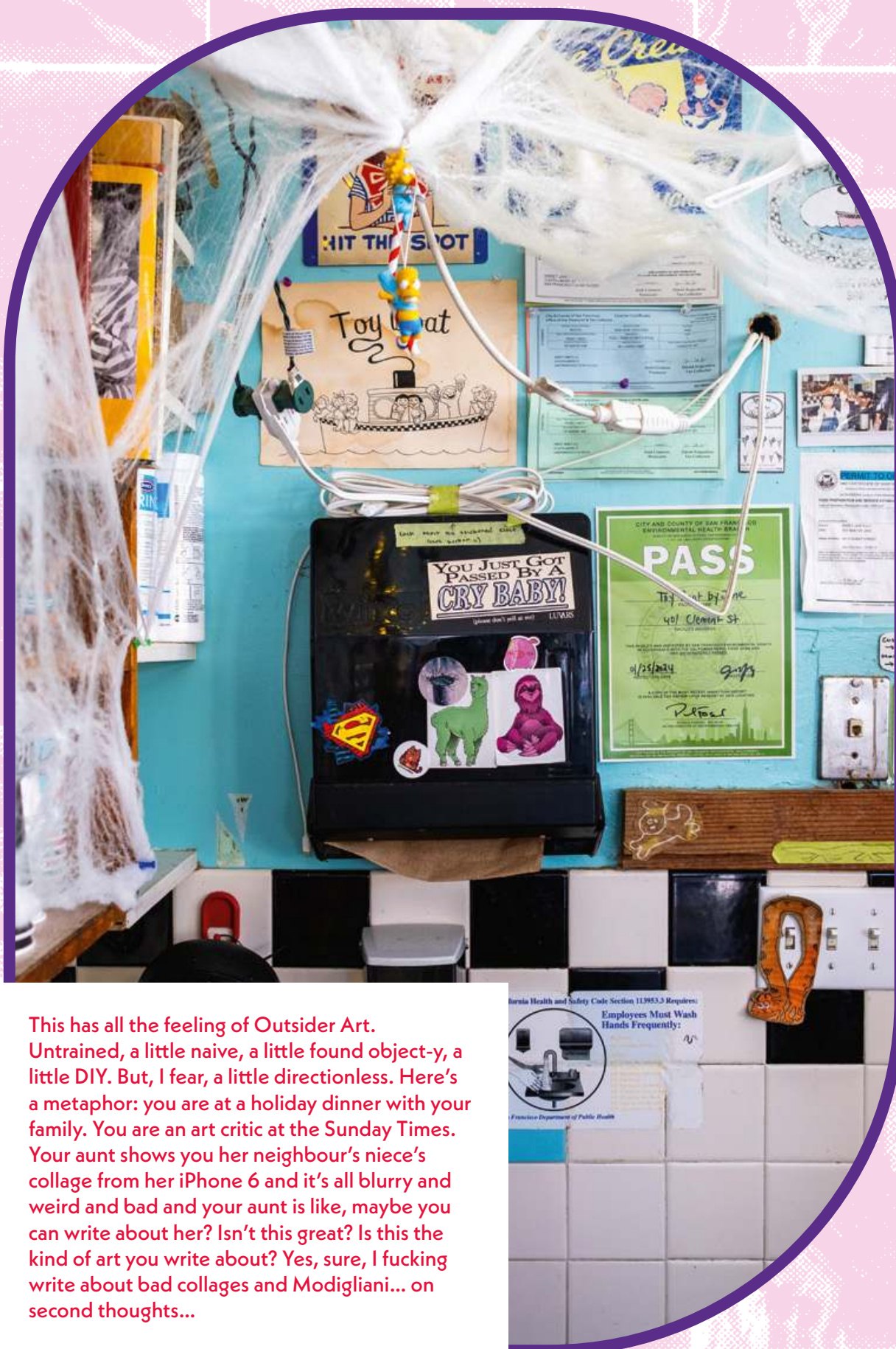
HOT, WET, AND NOISY HOT, WET, AND NOISY

When we came across photographer Samuel Ride's brilliant project of photographing hand dryers and towel dispensers around the world, we knew we had to put it in *Ralph*. And to give it the gravitas we think it deserves, we got Evan Pricco, ex-Editor-in-Chief of the globally respected art magazine *Juxtapoz*, to cast his arty eye over them for comment.

Words by Evan Pricco
Photos by Samuel Ride



The simplicity. The subtleness. The starkness. The cleanliness. The abstraction. The definition. The butterfly. The leaves falling. Now, just imagine this and then the absolutely obnoxious and horrifying noise this thing makes. It's a juxtaposition I dare you to ponder.



This has all the feeling of Outsider Art. Untrained, a little naive, a little found object-y, a little DIY. But, I fear, a little directionless. Here's a metaphor: you are at a holiday dinner with your family. You are an art critic at the Sunday Times. Your aunt shows you her neighbour's niece's collage from her iPhone 6 and it's all blurry and weird and bad and your aunt is like, maybe you can write about her? Isn't this great? Is this the kind of art you write about? Yes, sure, I fucking write about bad collages and Modigliani... on second thoughts...



Immediately upon seeing the legacy of Ms. Spears decorating and adorning the local hand dryer of a loo near you, I think about the power of the retrospective. We speak too often of legacy in one's life, but this sort of hang is like getting a mid-career retrospective at MoMA. Sure, she still has time to make some of her best work, but it's a lot of pressure to climb the mountain at such a young age. But she can... do it again?



I struggle when the wallpaper of pink reflects on the paper towel of white and it creates the illusion of a pink paper towel. It's like... what do we actually see? What is its true colour? What is the identity of the paper? It's in this moment, these moments, where the paper towel finds its meaning.



Hand dryers should take you somewhere outside of yourself and your present state of being. A jungle perhaps? A rainforest of your liking? What I want you to really think about is what the parrot's name is. Really dive into it. I think Phil. *ralph*



DRINKING GAMES

Is this the best Nintendo-themed bar on the planet?

Words by Daniel Robson
Photos by Azusa Takada

Welcome to 84hashi. Hidden away from the bustle of Tokyo's Shibuya district, this secret members-only Nintendo-themed bar is filled floor to ceiling - literally! - with priceless video game memorabilia.

When you open the door, the familiar "Secret Sound" jingle from *The Legend of Zelda* signals you've discovered a sacred space. A mini museum, 84hashi's walls and bar are lined with hand-drawn artwork by the likes of Shigeru Miyamoto (*Super Mario*), Eiji Aonuma (*The Legend of Zelda*) and Atsuko Nishida (*Pokémon*), as well as autographed game boxes, candid snaps of legendary developers, and more stories than you can imagine.

84hashi is the pride and joy of owner Toru Hashimoto. Better known as Chokan, he worked at Nintendo from April 1984 until December 1995, around the time of the NES and SNES, working behind the scenes on timeless classics like *Mother 2*, *Yoshi's Island* and *Donkey Kong Country*. Later, at the behest of Miyamoto, and partly funded by Nintendo, Chokan went on to found the dev support company Sarugakucho, where he worked on tuning and debugging for games by the house of Mario and many others. He stayed with Sarugakucho for about 20 years.

Chokan opened 84hashi in February 2015 on a whim while still working at Sakuragakuchō, and the bar remained strictly members-only until the pandemic, when he decided to open it up to visitors. Now, it opens to members in the evenings while operating the 84tour in the daytime, allowing non-members a chance to ask Chokan about his glory days.

While the bar is strewn with hundreds of unique items, one of Chokan's favourites is a Zippo lighter emblazoned with the *Mother 2* logo. "These were given to the production team," he explains. "It has my name etched on the back, so it's truly one of a kind." The

lighter sits in a cabinet alongside a sticky label from an original Family Computer cartridge for *Super Mario Bros*, still attached to its paper backing, which Chokan plucked from the production line and has kept in mint condition since 1985. "That's probably the rarest item in my collection," he confides.

A shelf lined with photo frames shows a young Chokan on his first day at Nintendo in 1984. A group of new hires sit in rows, wearing Nintendo uniforms and '80s haircuts, the boys at the back and the girls lined up in front. "It's a little old-fashioned," he laughs. "We had to wear a suit with an official Nintendo jacket. I think they still wear a uniform at Nintendo today."

As an employee, Chokan was a member of Nintendo's in-house baseball team the Mario Stars, and his baseball shirts from that time are displayed on hangers. "They don't fit me anymore," he deadpans. "There's a home shirt and an away shirt, as well as a jacket for winter games." Chokan points to a jacket with a picture of Mario and the legend "Nintendo Baseball Club Tokyo".

"I was a pitcher, and we used to play against staff from other game companies like Konami and Bandai," he says. "Sometimes we even won!"

The wall facing the entrance contains dozens of framed illustrations and autographed game boxes, with its centrepiece a bright picture of Mario drawn by Miyamoto himself and dated February 2015; a gift commemorating the opening of 84hashi. "I asked him to draw a picture of Mario eating with chopsticks, but Miyamoto said Mario wouldn't use chopsticks because he's American, so he's using cutlery instead."

It's a long story, but 84hashi's name is partly based on the Japanese word for chopsticks, "hashi". A nearby illustration drawn by *Zelda* producer Aonuma shows Link using chopsticks, in his left hand of course.



**“I just suddenly
heard a voice say,
‘You should open a bar’”**



Next to Mario is the sheet music to the timeless *Super Mario Bros* theme, handwritten and signed by composer Koji Kondo. “I’m pretty sure it’s a handwritten original from back in the day, not a photocopy,” says Chokan. “The only way to be sure would be to try using a pencil eraser on it, but I’m not that brave.”

And then there’s the *Pokémon* corner. A frame contains drawings and autographs from members of *Pokémon* development studio Game Freak, including Junichi Masuda, Ken Sugimori and Takao Unno, as well as a picture of Mew by that character’s creator Shigeki Morimoto. It also depicts Pikachu eating from an 84 bowl, the first time the yellow and black series mascot was ever officially drawn using chopsticks.

This part of the collection was actually scrawled directly onto the wall of 84hashi’s original location a few doors down the street, so when they moved, Chokan carefully peeled off the wallpaper and had it framed. It’s now surrounded by dozens of *Pokémon* plushies and yet more original artwork, including a picture of Pikachu and Umbreon by Atsuko Nishida, the artist who created them both, and who also designed 84hashi’s mascot character ha~sha.

I wasn’t joking about there being stuff on the ceiling. Look up, and you will see an upside-down playroom mat, with a Famicom console strewn in situ as if discarded mid-game by a 1980s toddler. “The ceiling stuck out here and I thought it looked ugly, so I added this display myself,” says Chokan. “It was really hard to stick that on the ceiling properly.” Speaking with *Ralph* in December 2025, exactly 30 years after he left Nintendo, Chokan reflects on his post-game-production life as a bar owner. “It’s very different work,” he says. “But I love being able to provide a place where people from the game industry can get together, especially when I see younger developers getting to know one another here.”

As for how he started 84hashi, he says, “In 2014, I was in a meeting and I just suddenly heard a voice say, ‘You should open a bar’. A year later the bar was open. I had never been interested in running a bar per se, and I didn’t really know how to do it, but I figured I should start something that was unlike other places and completely unique.”

“I used to love visiting the *Hard Rock Café* and seeing Paul McCartney’s signed bass guitar hanging on the wall. So I asked friends from the game industry to draw illustrations that I could display. The very first of those were probably a *Dragon Quest* Slime by (series creator) Yuji Horii, Aonuma’s Link illustration and the *Pokémon* artwork.”

Once 84hashi was open, Chokan faced the realities of operating a bar that was not open to the general public. “Some days were really dead,” he admits. “I would go three days without anyone coming, and I was worried. But over time, people came back, and they brought their friends.”

The first time I visited 84hashi was in 2018 or 2019, when a friend from the game industry invited me to join them. In those days, you had to be invited by a member several times before you could join yourself, and I only managed a couple of visits before the pandemic hit, threatening the future of Chokan’s secret club. Now I am a fully-fledged member, and frequently take gamer friends who are visiting Japan. It’s always fun to see their faces light up in this treasure trove of discovery.

You never know who will be on the next table. The venue has seen in-the-flesh visits from Nintendo veteran Takashi Tezuka, Kondo, Aonuma, Horii, *Kirby/Smash Bros* creator Masahiro Sakurai and *Kirby* producer Shinya Kumazaki – true luminaries of Japan’s game industry.

“The only one who hasn’t visited yet is Miyamoto,” says Chokan. “He was generous

enough to send his illustration of Mario from Kyoto to Tokyo when we opened, and I'd love him to visit someday, but I think it would be quite a responsibility if he did – so it's probably just as well."

If you do spot someone at 84hashi you'd like to say hi to, be sure to ask Chokan for an introduction first. He takes his members' privacy seriously.

"The idea was to create a community of people I could trust," he explains. "So I was quite strict about the membership system at first, and vetted the guests of our members personally."

It was 2020 when Chokan decided to loosen up the rules and allow visitors for the 84tour. But it almost didn't happen. The bar used to have a dedicated chef, and when the third chef in a row quit in January 2020, he thought about shutting the doors forever. "This really felt like the end of the road, and I decided to give up," recalls Chokan. "But 10 days before our planned closing date, I suddenly had the idea of operating a guided tour for tourists. So in February we worked out the details, and prepared to start the 84tour in April 2020."

Yep, you can guess what happened next.

"The pandemic was really hard for us. We had to close for a year, and keep paying rent the whole time. It was so expensive. But I still had the idea of the tour in mind, and I waited for the day we could reopen." The 84tour officially began in September 2022. For 9,999 yen (about £47), visitors with a reservation can join a 90-minute daytime session where they are guided around the exhibits by Chokan's staff and can take photos, order drinks, buy souvenirs and even become a member.

As you might expect, these daytime tours are nerdgasm central. "The tour visitors lose their minds as soon as they step through the door,"

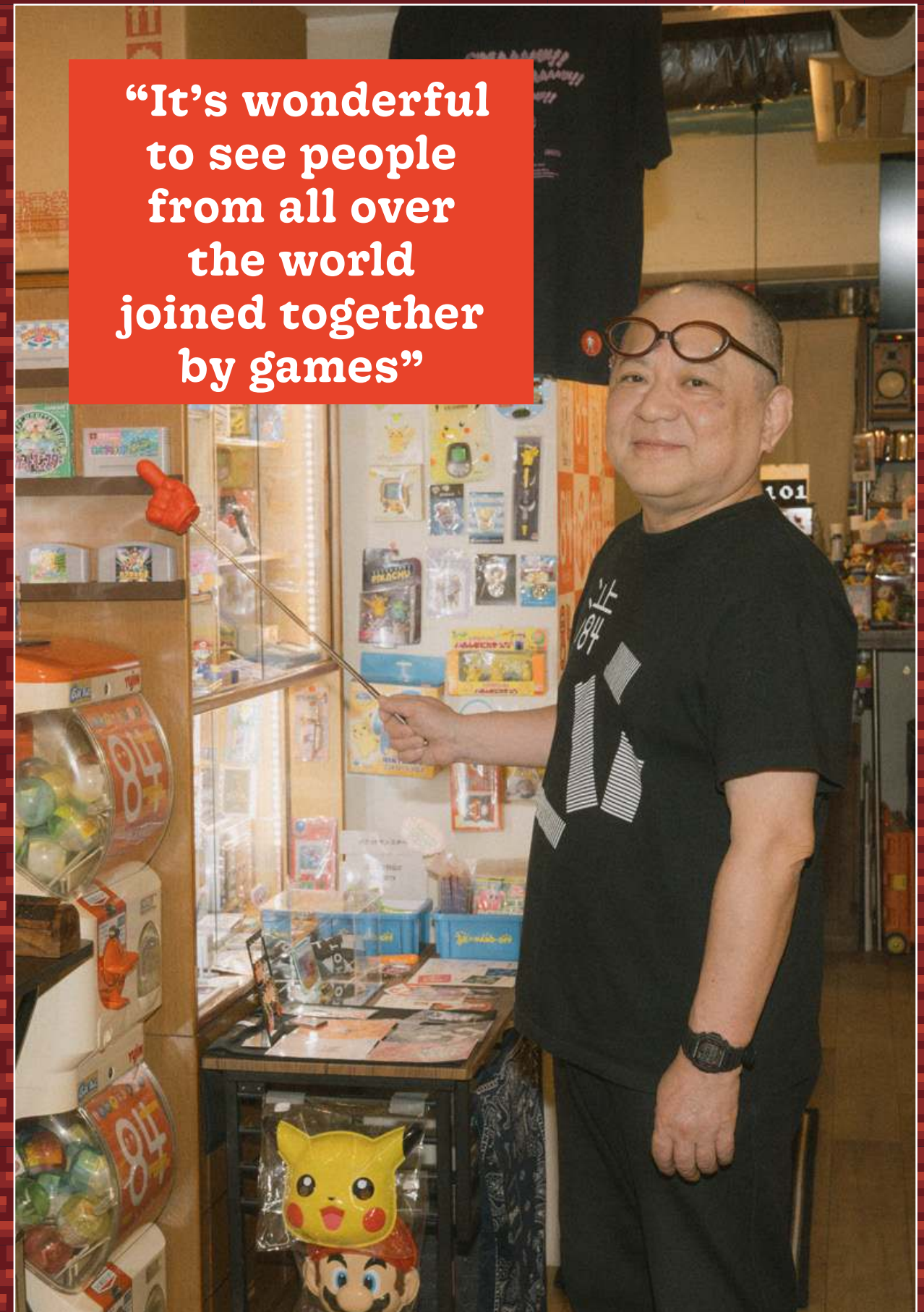
says Chokan. "We offer them a welcome drink, but they're too busy geeking out. I think it activates their childhood switch; the stuff on the walls reminds them of their first game console or some other core memory. It's wonderful to see people from all over the world joined together by games." Some visitors love the bar so much they become an official supporter, making a donation and gaining a plaque inside the door, a tradition that began in 2024. The most recent plaque enshrines the support of *Undertale* creator Toby Fox.

Over four decades on from his first day at Nintendo, Chokan has seen Japan's game industry rise and fall, and rise again. The Nintendo Switch and Switch 2 now dominate global console sales, while games from *Mario Kart* and *Pokémon*, to *Resident Evil* and *Elden Ring* bring different artistic visions from Japanese creators to millions around the world. "Back in the day, games were considered a corrupting force that would prevent kids from studying and forming relationships," he considers. "But now games are seen as something that can bring people together across generations and borders. They've become a communication tool. I think that's a wonderful thing. It's no longer a subculture, but a culture."

There are, of course, museums around the world that preserve vintage items of gaming history, including the Nintendo Museum in Kyoto – but 84hashi is not that. Just like the *Hard Rock Café* did for music, 84hashi is a place to see items touched by the people who make our favourite games.

In Japan, the retirement age is 65, a milestone Chokan will reach next year – but what will happen to his Shibuya home in future? "I'd like the younger generation of game developers to continue to have a place to gather, so I think I'll keep operating this place until the day I die," he says. "After that, I'm not sure. I'm trying not to think about it!" *ralph*

"It's wonderful to see people from all over the world joined together by games"



BIRD IS THE WORD

Caitlin Moran's on the hunt for the next great writer – but we mostly talked about birds...

Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by Dan Wilton



I've spent a lot of time trying to think of an original metaphor or simile for a really good conversation. I started by comparing it to a hit of nitrous oxide, in the way that the world just falls away during it, but soon realised the similarities between nitrogen flavoured asphyxia and a lovely chat do really begin and end there – NOS only lasts a few seconds.

I pivoted a little to trial 'a good chat is like a really good acid trip' thing and then promptly bailed on it because, in all honesty, they're not really that similar are they? One is a satiating intellectual exchange between people on any given subject, and the other is a half terrifying, half hilarious voiding of your senses for 12 hours during which you can never be 100% certain you haven't pissed yourself.

The most successful of all my comparisons, I'd say, is that a really good conversation is like really good sex. As a comparison it does, for the most part, stand up to scrutiny. Lots of backing and forthing in both. Chemistry is a necessity. Equal time or attention given to each other's... ideas. Where it does fall down is that I often enjoy a really good chat with my Mum and I think, if it's ok with you, I'd like to keep a bit of separation between church and state where the two offerings in this comparison are concerned.

All of this somewhat failed search for a metaphor is to say, best-selling author, iconic feminist and award-winning journalist, Caitlin Moran is an excellent chat. When we met off east London's iconic Brick Lane, the world very much fell away. I walked away from the conversation energised, full up with stories and ideas (having unloaded a load of my own) and gratified. What's more, everyone breathed throughout, no one pissed themselves (that I know of), and no one accidentally banged their mum to make a (wholly unnecessary) literary point... so a win all round really.

Ostensibly, we came together to film an episode of Ralph's interview series *What Do You Want To Talk About?* to celebrate the Young Writers' Prize, which Caitlin, who was homeschooled in a council house in Wolverhampton with her seven siblings, has set up with the *British Society of Magazine Editors*.

Before any of that though, our conversation started where you might expect it to... birds. That's actually a lie. Before we'd even started rolling, Caitlin and I had managed to cover smoking (cool), vaping (weird), giving them both up (hard), the Beckham beef (a parable for all the dysfunctional men currently fucking up the world) and, finally, making bad decisions on [redacted - Ed]. I shan't regale you with the full anecdote, but it involved a concussion, an iconic '90s band and quite a lot of enhanced hubris.

It was when we finally started recording (much to our producer's relief), that the conversation turned to birds. "Bird watching is the perfect hobby if you have ADHD," Moran muses. "If you pop a bird feeder in your garden, every 30 seconds something just turns up. You're constantly getting a dopamine hit without using social media." Conversation turns quickly to the flocks of parakeets that live in the treetops near where we both live. We agree that whilst they are very bad for native populations of birds and the balance of nature, it is extremely exciting that we literally have "flocks of parrots in North London." I proffer that the exuberant invader is simply a brat pigeon, Moran counters with "drag pigeon". A good time is being had by all.

"I've recently rewilded and put in a load of bird feeders. I'm starting to attract new species and I'm absolutely convinced they talk to each other. The magpie that comes up and asks me for food on the Heath does so because they've heard about me from other birds. The other day they [the birds] brought me a great metaphor for life," she tells me. "We've got these big Victorian sash windows



“Birdwatching is the perfect hobby if you have ADHD”

“The other day the birds brought me a great metaphor for life”





and a couple of weeks ago I heard a banging in my daughter's bedroom."

Between the panes of glass, in a space too narrow to get your hand down into, was a bird, trapped. The fact you couldn't get your hand down didn't really matter, as it turns out, because every time Caitlin tried to rescue it, the trapped bird would "pass out because its heart was racing."

"I stood there looking at it thinking 'what am I going to do?! What can I do!' In the end, I put a stick down there, and just left it in the hope it would learn to climb up the stick and fly away," Caitlin recounts – she is a captivating storyteller both on and off the page and here she takes sips from her Le Creuset coffee flask (chic) to punctuate the tale. "After two agonising hours of it sort of getting to the top, then coming back down again, then going back up, it finally was free and I realised what an incredible metaphor for parenting it is."

The more one interferes and helps directly,

Moran philosophises, the more likely they (your children) are to freak out. "You have to try and find a way to give them some kind of moral or philosophical stick that eventually they can climb up and fly away."

As a fairly newly-minted step-parent, it feels nice to know that other people are also desperately turning to nature for a sign of what the hell we're supposed to be doing. Parenting, I opine, is a lot of lying. Both to the children and awake at night stressing about them. My opening gambits into the world of parental advice are warmly received by Caitlin (a relief because otherwise I'd just admitted to lying to children on camera for nothing) and so I carry on with my theory that there is a lot of, not bullying, but certainly a lot of persuading to do the right thing (wash hands after toilet, eat vegetables, brush teeth for more than three seconds etc.). She nods enthusiastically. Convincing children to undertake hygienic practice is something Caitlin knows about. I continued,

in what many are labelling the [*this is actually impressive* - Ed] world's greatest segue:

Aged 15, Moran won the *Observer's Young Reporter of the Year* award for a 'war report' on the experience of cajoling her younger brother into having a bath. "I talked to the judges afterwards and everyone else wrote very pious reports of a local sportsman who came to town or a local bypass," she explains. "I decided I didn't care about the news and I didn't want to report on something boring, so I did a comedy war report in the style of [iconic war correspondent] Kate Adie about how difficult it was to put a child in the bath. There was screaming, fighting back, at one point it escaped and we tracked it down and we brought it back and in that moment I won my entire future."

"There is," Caitlin contends, "no other way to get from a council estate in Wolverhampton to eventually being published in newspapers that doesn't involve going to Oxford or Cambridge, or one of your parents working in the media... It changed my life."

She's not joking. A year after winning, Moran had her first column at music magazine *Melody Maker*. By 18 she was a columnist for *The Times*, where she has remained, penning two columns a week. She has written books which have sold millions and been turned into major Hollywood productions, and Channel 4 developed and broadcast *Raised By Wolves* – a sitcom about her childhood (co-written with her sister). Journalism has opened up doors to rooms that Caitlin didn't know existed. She has spent the last three plus decades experiencing things everyone else can only read about through her words. Caitlin's is a career that many dream of and it's one she's actively looking to share. She describes herself as being obsessed with class and tells me that she's also obsessed with the idea that "the future is going to be brilliant."

It's a welcome salve to the doom-mongering of my own analysis of the future (bad) and it's within that kernel of infectious hope that the idea of this new prize for young writer's that

Caitlin's so animated about, comes from.

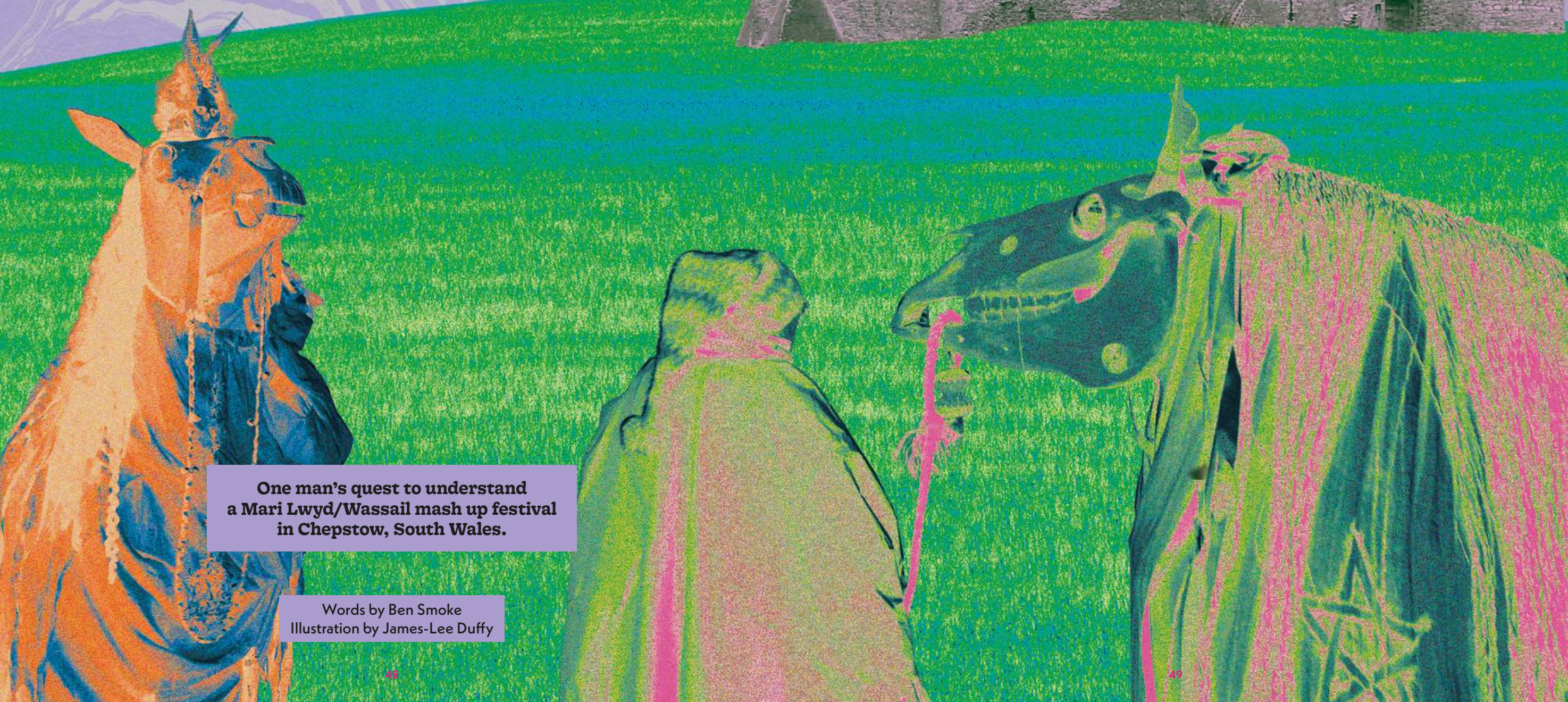
"It's something I'm really passionate about," Moran explains, "not just because I'm a really noble, smashing human being, but because I get bored really easily. Every time I read a newspaper or magazine, I'm really aware that the majority of the pieces in there are written by the same kind of person from the same kind of background and it's just boring!"

The prize launches this spring and includes a cash bursary, one year of personal mentorship from Caitlin, plus internships or work experience placements with leading UK magazines and online publications. She's on the hunt to find the next generation of columnists, authors and screenwriters from estates up and down the country. The prize was developed by the *British Society of Magazine Editors* in conjunction with Caitlin (who was their 2024 *Columnist of the Year*) to open doors for young writers who show exceptional promise but lack the connections or resources to break into journalism. "I want to know what's happening in towns across the country. I want kids who are sitting in their bedrooms to just tell me what they're like. What are they doing? Who are they talking to? Who do they love? Who do they hate? What are they wearing? How are they having sex?" she laughs.

Whether it's hurriedly writing live reviews of Madonna on the venue floor with a just-stomped-on laptop (this is a true story) to her beloved columns and interviews, and any number of tales from her youth, Caitlin's is a life rich in story. Now, she's looking for the next great storyteller to give a metaphorical stick to, so they can fly high too. *ralph*

If you're between the ages of 18 and 25 and, like Caitlin, you want to conquer the world with your original takes and witty copy, you can enter the competition at <https://www.bsme.com/bursary>

Straight From The Horse's Mouth



One man's quest to understand
a Mari Lwyd/Wassail mash up festival
in Chepstow, South Wales.

Words by Ben Smoke
Illustration by James-Lee Duffy

I worry people think I lie at work. I recently got an email to explain an invoice for a car booked in my name. I replied, "OK so, this is going to seem untrue but it's a car for me and Ashley [a producer at Ralph] to get a very early train from Paddington to Wales to hang out with a load of Welsh people hiding under cloaks while holding decorated horse skulls that were fixed on poles."

"Lo!, OK" came the reply.

Sliding the door to the cab open at 5:30am, it was still pitch black, as is want to be at that time in the morning. I thought wearing sunglasses would help ease my way into the day. In reality, they just obscured my already poor vision, managing to misjudge the step up to the vehicle, causing the skinny latte (iced) I had in my hand to spray all over the upholstery (unchic). Not the auspicious start I'd hoped for.

After picking up Ashley, we whizzed through the streets of north London and within half an hour Paddington station suddenly announced itself with its Brunellian arches and its unflattering fluorescent lighting. Finally, those sunglasses not looking like such a bad idea...

About 200km west of Paddington is a place called 'Severn Tunnel Junction'. You're not going to believe this, but Severn Tunnel Junction lies at the junction of the tunnel under the River Severn, the South Wales Main Line from London and the Gloucester to Newport Line. And where we disembarked to change trains.

It is, as the deeply unimaginative name suggests, one of those places where hope goes to die. It was cold. It was grey. The one "building" (a cabin at best) was a locked toilet. There were fields full of sheep for basically as far as the eye could see but for the giant Severn Suspension Bridge, painting

itself against the never ending clouds.

"Welcome to Wales!" I quipped to Ashley – a native Californian – as we waited for our next train.

Wales is a place of great contradictions. A country of breathtaking natural beauty in places like the Gower, the Brecon Beacons and Snowdonia, that also encompasses heavy industrial past and present in the shape of dirty and hard coal mines of the Valleys and the giant steel works of Port Talbot. A place where wealth drenched neighbourhoods like the Mumbles sit just a few miles from Swansea's Townhill estate. A nation who are fiercely proud of their heritage, but whose language nearly died.

As we waited, huddled together in the shelter, a group of women arrived on the platform. They were sensibly bundled up against the rain and wind so it was hard to tell exactly what they were wearing but they had the air of synchronicity about them. "I bet they're going where we're going," I muttered to Ashley without turning my head to look at her. I was aiming for subtle and wise. In hindsight, given I still had my sunglasses on, I probably landed closer to Jamie Foxx's Oscar winning performance in *Ray*.

Our train to Chepstow finally arrived and the group of women followed us in, shedding their outer layers to reveal co-ordinated outfits (some classy subtle pinks and maroons) underneath. They had more than a whiff of Morris dancer about them (non-derogatory) and they did indeed get off the train at our destination. "I was right," I whispered to Ashley, doing my best impression of Al Pacino's Oscar winning performance in *Scent of a Woman*.

We followed them through the quaint streets of Chepstow. We walked through a path in a churchyard that you just know goes off from April - December with light and colour and foliage before arriving at the Drill Hall, Chepstow's art and community centre, which



was to be the staging post for this year's Mari Lwyd festival.

The tradition, dating back to at least 1800, marks the Welsh New Year. The 'Mari' in Mari Lwyd is a horse skull attached to a pole with a cloak (bedsheet) flowing underneath it. Some skulls are real, others are 3D printed. The skull is decorated with eyes, tassels, and hats. Each Mari has its own tradition and colour scheme – one of them, for instance, looked like it had just walked out of Cyberdog in 2008. Others were a bit more subtle. I mean, as subtle as a decorated horse's skull can be.

But where do they procure horse skulls from? One man, who came from across the border in Dartmoor, was at great pains to tell me his Mari, which was beautifully decorated by his late wife, wasn't technically a real Welsh one as he procured the skull from a local butcher. Others said that theirs were heirlooms (I decided not to pull too hard on that thread).

Whoever holds the Mari gets under the cloak (sheet) so you can't tell who it is. They are then led around town, knocking on doors, going into pubs, playing word games with people. Generally being tricky. The tradition was started by those working in agriculture who did not have much but would, it seems, have lots of horse skulls lying around.

Chepstow's Mari Lwyd is a little different to the other celebrations across Wales. Instead of one Mari making her way through the town, there are about a dozen. That's because Widders Border Morris, the group who organise this particular event, invite different Maris and Morris dancing groups (sides) to participate. Groups come from all over south Wales and across the border from nearby towns in England.

We waited in the Drill Hall, as the Mari/Morris folk began to arrive. They stood in little huddles around the space, soundtracked by the constant jingling of bells that were attached to various arms, legs and horse

skulls. Each group, like their Mari, had a different vibe. A different theme and colour scheme. Some had a sort of purple raven situation. Others were more "of the woods". The women from the train were there, now decked in full regalia, a "full vindication for me," I whispered to Ashley, sunglasses now off my face, which is good because I've run out of actors who won an Oscar for playing visually impaired or blind people.

It was among this chorus of chatter and jangle and colour that I met Gareth John who was to be the Mari for Widders Border Morris this year. Gareth looked Welsh, if you know what I mean. Strawberry blonde and built for rugby, he was quintessentially 'ruddy' in the best way. He was warm and inviting, and it was clear that he bloody loves Chepstow.

Though Gareth was born 20 miles away in Newport, he has lived in Chepstow for almost two decades. Having previously worked for the tourism board, Gareth had a deep well of knowledge about the town, excitedly pointing out locations on a giant aerial photo of the place hanging on the wall of the Drill Hall. He talked me through the Mari Lwyd festival and how it had nearly died out 20 years ago, but that the Widders Border Morris group had resurrected it.

Gareth invited me to follow along as they walked up into the town to get up to some mischief – which is very much an invitation I could not refuse. As we walked from the hall, past the giant, imposing castle, we stopped off at the local Mencap centre, that supports people with learning disabilities. Those who use the space had repurposed their Christmas tree into a giant Mari and excitedly told us all about it. As we carried on our procession up the street, pictures of Maris appeared in almost all of the windows of the houses we passed. A lot of time, work and care had obviously gone into some of the displays.

As the road opened up into the bottom of Chepstow's Market Square, it felt like the whole town was involved. Despite



“Once we’d finished shouting at the trees, it was time for the Maris to play ding dong ditch”

the biting cold wind and incessant rain, crowds had formed around the different performance spaces, where each Morris side took it in turns to perform their own styles of dance. Some were soundtracked by singers, others by full bands.

One of the great things about Chepstow, Gareth told me, was that it was a border town, so the traditions and customs of both the Welsh and the English merged – which brings us to Wassail. Whilst the Mari Lwyd is a South Walian tradition, the Wassail is English. A Wassail is traditionally held in January and is a custom that dates back to 1100. The act of Wassailing is done to encourage a plentiful harvest from apple trees and, in Chepstow at least, the ceremony was led by a “butler” but, I’m going to go out on a limb here, and say this is not his full time profession.

In short, the ceremony includes three distinctive parts with lots of singing and cider drinking in between. The first is pouring cider on the roots of the trees and dancing around them. That did feel a little like making a pig eat a ham sandwich, then doing a jig but I decided to keep quiet. I wouldn’t have been heard anyway, as hundreds of people clamoured around the orchard, having walked from the town in a big procession. They stood high up on the surrounding hills to catch a glimpse of the ceremony.

The second part of the ceremony involved screaming at the trees to rid them of evil spirits which, in all seriousness, is the sort of thing I could see myself getting involved with in my own spare time so I will leave

passing comment on it to you. The third and final part of the ceremony involved hanging bits of toast from the branches of the tree. Each phase seemed to have a different song, belted out by two women in Britney mics wearing traditional Welsh dress (big skirts, thick woollen shawls, tall hat).

Once we’d finished shouting at the trees, it was time for the Maris to play ding dong ditch at the 1000-year-old Chepstow Castle (do you see now why people think I am lying for attention!). Onlookers lined the long, sweeping path up to the giant, medieval doors to the castle and awaited the procession of Maris, led by the Welsh Britneys. When they finally made it up the hill (one characteristic of all Maris is that they’re unrushable) there was a back and forth of word games in Welsh and English with those inside the castle, all broadcast over a crackly sound system before the Maris were let in. As the doors shuttered, like with most British traditions, the crowds slunk off to the pub.

Later, as Ashley and I made our way back through the town back to our hotel, the streets were eerily quiet but for one figure, striding with purpose up the hill. As he approached, I realised it was Gareth. He beamed at us as he looked out over the square, which had been the site of much of the days festivities and declared, “It was brilliant. Just brilliant!” Pride and joy etched over his face. And I guess, after all of that, there are no ways to describe the festival, the town or its people other than brilliant.

Just brilliant. *ralph*



BORED? LISTEN TO THIS

We asked London-based MC, songwriter, DJ and radio host, Idris Miles to “do a playlist about anything” for this issue of the mag. And he came back with one called “ways to dance away your boredom”. Idris is renowned for his intricate lyrical story telling, slick bars, high energy, and his sense of humour. Championed by the likes of BBC Introducing, and with a sound taking in R&B, drill, rap, garage, grime and hip-hop, you might have caught Idris on things like DJ AG’s infamous livestreams, his radio show on Loose.fm or performing live up and down the country.

Dessie

Malfunction Afrofusion

Antslive

First Class Landing (feat. Knucks and Bawo)

GIANT

AH TXE TXE

Blissfool

Finding Butterflies

Idris Miles

CORRECTANDSMOOTH (feat. MEGAMiKES)

Sam One

Kitale

Aminé

Feel So Good

ClubCamo

Do Ya Love Me? #Jerseyclub

Mohombi

Stuck on you

Kokoriko

Sweetie



Idris Miles' single 'CorrectAndSmooth' featuring Megamikes is out now
You can follow him @idris Miles_

SCAN TO LISTEN



DRESSING AND IMPRESSING

How to be a Costume Designer

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Jess Govinden

Ian Fulcher is a BAFTA-nominated costume designer who's worked on iconic TV shows like It's A Sin, Giri/Haji, and A Very British Scandal. He also co-runs the hire company CostumeEast – a massive warehouse full to the brim of brilliant clothes, hats, roller skates and a cat face I may or may not have cut my nose on while taking silly pictures for Ralph's Art Director. It's in amongst these wonderful clothes we met him to chat about being a costume designer for TV and film to continue our 'How To Be A...' series.

How did you get into costume design?

I studied fashion, design and marketing and set up a little label in Birmingham, where I'm from, called Graham and Lucy, which we used to sell on the market stall and shops. Then we were invited by Birmingham City Council to design costumes for a big dance piece, which piqued my interest in costume design. I moved down to London and saw an advert for a job at [iconic costume suppliers] Angels who did this amazing training programme. At the time I didn't really know what costume was or how it fitted into working in film or TV. I'm also really passionate about history – I actually did a project where I researched and drew womenswear of every decade from the 1500s onwards. When I went for the interview at Angels, things came together and I could see how productions draw and source their inspiration from costumes. I worked there for three years and really built up a knowledge of the foundations of clothing. I knew how clothes from different eras should look, but I'd never known how they were actually put together. We used to have lessons every Wednesday where we were taught how to put costumes from various eras together. I got offered a job in 'Ladies Period', which went up to the 1960s. When I left, I worked with a designer called Ralph Wheeler-Holes who I got on very well with. He kindly employed me to do fittings on a film he was doing and

from there I became his assistant and then supervisor. Ralph taught me a lot and was very supportive. He guided me into the production side for five years, before I made the jump to designing for myself. My first client was doing costumes for commercials for the government. Then my first film was awful, I got so stressed I got eight boils on my bottom. I remember being on the phone to my mum because I didn't have enough money to buy multiple costumes and the film wouldn't give me any more. My mum generously put some money in my account to help so she essentially financed the costumes of the film! Things slowly grew to where we're at now!

What do you do if a lead actor stinks?

[laughing] You speak to the wardrobe supervisor who'll have a quiet word and ensure that – if the clothing allows – you put in enough sweat pads. If they're hygienically-challenged, then I guess that's got to be embraced and the clothing needs to be maintained. I must say I've never really worked with anyone like that. Fittings are really sacred spaces because the actors are practically naked and quite vulnerable, and I think they know that when they arrive. It's my job to make them comfortable.

And breathe through your mouth? It must be extremely intimate!

One of the first things I ask is how they feel. To me, things start from the shoe up and if they've got to feel comfortable and right. If they don't feel right or confident in any way I'll get them just to take it off and we move on. I never try and force something onto someone – unless the part really calls for it.

Like "You're a knight, you have to wear a helmet, not a trilby"?

[laughing] "I want to be a really jaunty knight that's just swinging on by".

Is Vinted like a mecca for you?

Yes and no. Personally I find the website really frustrating but I know my team and the crowd team will buy a lot from there





because it's such a good price. I think ASOS Marketplace has gone now but that used to be amazing. You'd have all these sellers from eastern Europe who'd have really cool and interesting pieces from the '80s and '90s. Also, because our timelines are so short, using something like that doesn't work. One of the restrictions when you're prepping someone is that casting can happen very late – sometimes you'll be casting the day before they're on camera, or they'll be cast but won't be flying in from another country till two days before filming.

Do you liaise mainly with the director or producer?

If you're doing a multi-episodic series then it's generally broken down into blocks. So if it's a six-parter, you'll shoot episodes 1-3 with one director then the second block with another. Before we start, we'll be given the scripts for each block of episodes ahead of each filming so we can be reading them, researching, getting visuals, and that's when I speak to the director with input from the writer. Then I'll go off and do concept boards for every character, which are generally three or four pages. Although for Keira Knightley in *Black Doves* I think she had 30 or 40 pages as she had so many looks. From those concept boards I'll have a meeting with director and producer to go through them and pick out core images – or get rid of ones which are just wrong! Then I'll redo them and I'll send them to the actors once they've been cast. That starts a whole new discourse because they'll have their own vision of how the character should look. So then we have to bring those two visuals together to create that character. I don't really speak to PR companies to get clothes, I'd rather source them myself. If I can't find the specific clothes I want, or need a certain colour of fabric that I just can't find, then I'll start making it. And then after that you have your first fitting! We're looking for what colours work on the actor and from there it's the foundation. Sometimes you can have a rail of costumes where everything on it is perfect or where only one thing works.

For the lead characters they'll have four or five more fittings before the filming starts, depending on what's being made. When you multiply that across all the actors you and the team are just... managing very well!

How often do you make bespoke stuff?

For contemporary costumes I tend to make quite a lot of them so I can get exactly my vision. I always have a very strong colour palette and I have a very strong vision of how I want things to look, and you sometimes can't find that. Also I sometimes don't like buying things from the high street as there's a chance it could end up on another job that comes out before my one! On *Black Doves* I was looking at a jacket in a shop for Sam Riley's character but decided against it and it did appear on another programme! When I did *A Very British Scandal*, which was a period job, I'd say 90% of the clothing was made bespoke. They were playing high society people and I wanted to give a little bit of contemporary edge to it. I think Claire Foy had about 80 costumes made for her and Paul Bettany had all his suiting and shirts made. Claire had all her gloves made for her.

Do the actors have to wear bespoke underwear too?

They do! Bras, for instance, have to be a certain shape for the character and when it's based. I always say that the exterior only comes from the foundation – the underpinnings – say, for example, the '50s you'd nip it in at the waist and have a certain shaped bra that gives that silhouette that is more identifiable for the period.

How many people are in your team for, say, a six-parter Netflix show?

I would say around 15 people who work on the whole show, then on top of that core team you have what are called 'dailies' who come in to be a crowd buyer or assistants on set or fitters. So you could have 30-40 people. If it's a period or a fancy job it can have even more. It becomes this huge web of

“There was no way in hell I was putting anyone in a ra-ra skirt”

sourcing and fitting. My team does that and I’m overseeing it. I live on Whatsapp!

***It’s a Sin* was set mainly in the '80s. How do you avoid dressing everyone in caricature costumes from the era?**

Avoiding that dangerous territory of just being pastiche. It’s funny, because I remember somebody saying, “Ah I remember we used to wear ra-ra skirts” and me thinking there was no way in hell I was going to put anyone in a ra-ra skirt. For *It’s a Sin*, we watched a documentary on the opening of Heaven nightclub – one of the most famous gay clubs that’s still open today. What was brilliant was the men inside are wearing V-necked jumpers and shirts on. The DJ’s wearing a tank top with a shirt and tie. That to me is amazing, there’s no nudity, like today! They were wearing knitwear and polyester and they all looked so real. For me, that was about ensuring people looked real. *It’s a Sin* starts in 1981 and finishes in 1991, and what I loved about the early '80s parts were that the clothes were still very '70s. You don’t really think about that. I was finding brilliant pictures of these kids wearing huge collared leather jackets because they’d be wearing hand-me-down clothes. Another really good resource is through photojournalism and there are some incredible books at The Photographers’ Gallery in Soho, documenting real life.

Would you say your specialism was British looks? You’ve done *It’s a Sin*, *A Very British Scandal* and even *Giri*/

***Haji* was set half in London, half Tokyo.**

I would say it depends on the job. I guess it would appear to be my specialism because of the jobs I’ve done, but in *It’s A Sin*, we had some scenes set in New York so I was researching those styles and pushed that look for that section of the production. With *Giri/Haji* I actually got to go to shoot in Japan for three months – and I realise that was an absolute privilege to do, and going to locations is one of my favourite things of the job. I went for a recce and was surprised how Americanised a lot of the clothing is, although the Japanese do have a certain way of dressing that I only really absorbed when I was there. In terms of my design, I wouldn’t say the British look was necessarily stronger. That’s just the way it’s gone so far.

What’s your favourite part of your job? The concepting, the creation or the seeing it all come together on an actor?

Ooh that’s difficult. I would say it’s the initial design and conceptualising and when you first start the journey, because it’s exciting. It also can be quite stressful because you want to make sure you’re starting the journey correctly – that’s the exciting bit. And then you go up the rocky road of being nervous when you have the first set of fittings, and then when they’re first on camera. It’s a rollercoaster of nerves and excitement I would say. Then, at the very end when you’re at the end, watching the screening, the feeling of achievement is amazing. *edp*

IAN FULCHER’S TOP TIPS TO BE A COSTUME DESIGNER

PEOPLE SKILLS

On any production you work with such a variety of people and personalities, from the seriously shy to the egocentric, from Gen Z trainees to octogenarian actors. It’s always the aim to get the best out of people!

MY TEAM

I wouldn’t be anywhere without my team supporting me, or myself supporting them. Every person plays such an important part.

LEARNING

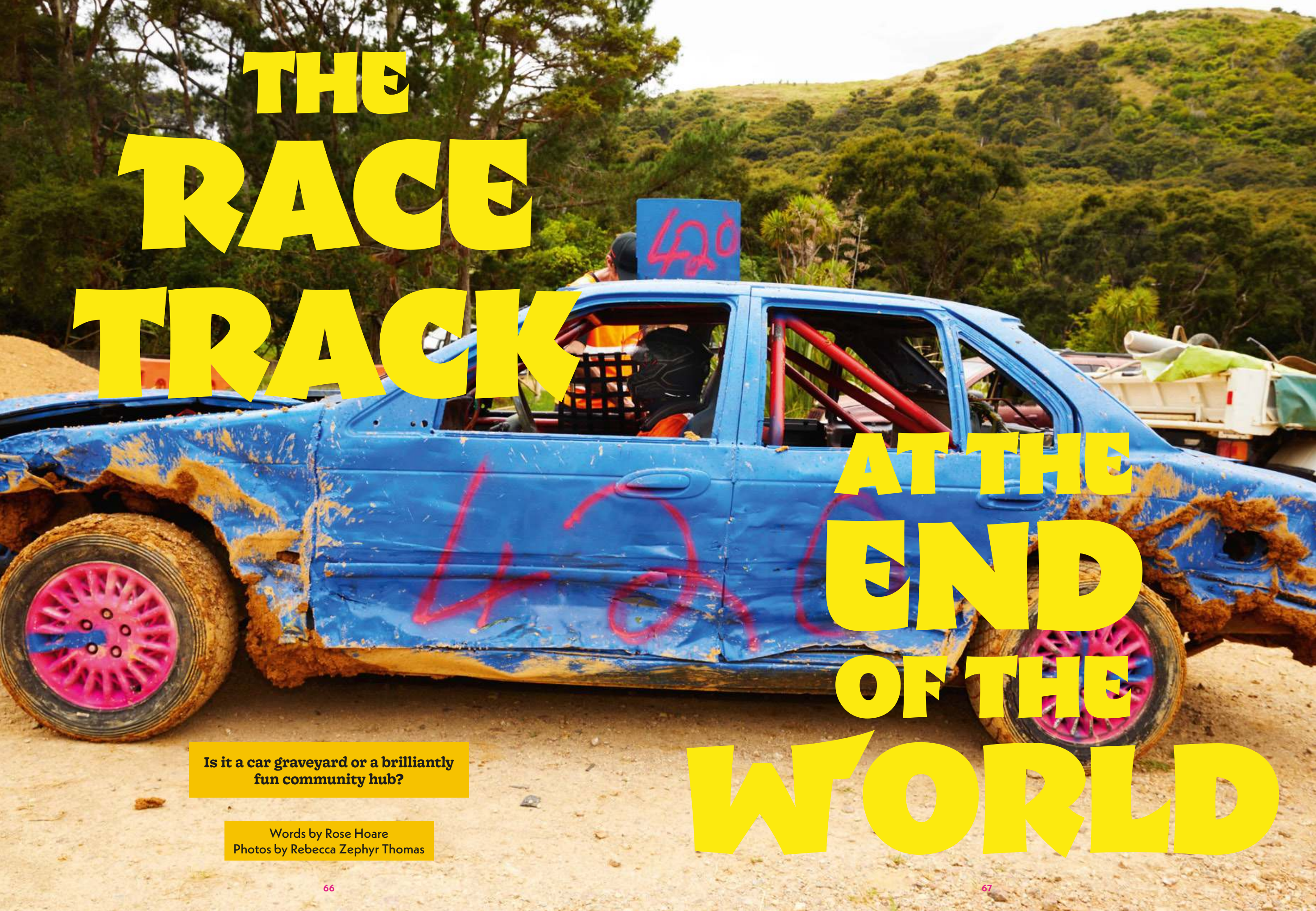
Every job is different and there are always new things to learn. From researching a certain period in history to using new technology, or old technology for that matter!

CONFIDENCE

Having the confidence to put a point across and not be offended if it’s dismissed. Strength comes from knowing when to submit.

HUMOUR

You’ve gotta have fun on a job, life’s way too short to not!



THE RACE TRACK

AT THE END OF THE WORLD

Is it a car graveyard or a brilliantly
fun community hub?

Words by Rose Hoare
Photos by Rebecca Zephyr Thomas

Waiheke Island: where Aucklanders with infinity pools live alongside neighbours in yurts and houseboats. Around the 1350s, a great oceangoing Māori waka made landfall here after a 4000km journey. Today, beneath a hill named for their chief's topknot, sits the Waiheke Dirt Track Club, where knackered cars go to die a glorious death.

The club has a simple deal: can't pass your Warrant of Fitness? Donate your clapped-out Nissan Pulsar, Mitsubishi Lancer or Mazda Familia. Volunteers cage it, strip it, then spend a year thrashing it around a clay speedway before it meets the crusher.

The vibe at Sunday's race meet is beautifully chaotic: white-haired bloke climbing out of a car window Daisy Duke-style, cigarette dangling; hungover announcer with a Waiheke tattoo kept company by his blueberry-gobbling toddler; cicadas and the smell of warm, clay-baked mature car.

The cars make stertorous groans, flatulent noises, clicking and popping – like my middle-aged body getting out of bed – before topping out at about 60km/h. One sheds a tire into the long grass. Time for the kids' lolly scramble anyway. Spectators back their flatbed trucks in so their kids

have a viewing platform. Others recline on the hillside like Seurat's picnickers, if Seurat painted dingy-up cars.

First-timer Bonnie, 21, drifts her dad's Commodore into a bank, then course-corrects and floors it, and my heart soars. Another first-timer, Holly, 25, loses to Jimbo but wins her second race. Everyone's stoked for these newcomers, even though nobody knows them.

When the three most senior drivers battle it out, you somehow sense decades of camaraderie in how their cars interact on the course – they're not just racing, they're playing. The track's watered so much I'm told it can feel more like ice-skating than driving.

The club has a rare sense of goodwill that draws you into its orbit. A community group is allowed to compost here. The local high school band gigs in the clubrooms. One member's grateful they let his delinquent in-laws graffiti the cars in psychotic hot pink.

Post-race prize-giving in the old woolshed: "Dummy of the Day" (arrived late, car didn't work), "Dipstick of the Day" (loaned his car to someone who crashed it). Holly, Bonnie and three other first-time winners get ceremonial buckets of water dumped on their heads. They handle it like champs. *ralph*







MENTALLY FERAL,



Superstar comedian Joanne McNally talks selling out arenas, money, and not following the rules

Words by Alexandra Haddow
Photos by Stephanie Sian Smith
Art Direction by James-Lee Duffy

Yellow Jacket by Dolce & Gabbana (available at Designer Exchange), white T-Shirt by Mia Mia (available at Designer Exchange), trousers by Adidas, boots by Dr Martens, jewellery by Tilly Sveas, Edge of Ember, Celeste Starre and Joanne's own

Top by Adidas, bags by Anxious Preoccupied, sunglasses by Balenciaga, jewellery by Tilly Sveas, Edge of Ember, Celeste Starre and Joanne's own.



PHYSICALLY GROOMED

Whenever I read a celebrity profile in Vanity Fair or The New Yorker, the writer and the interviewee seem to have some glamorous previous personal connection where they were neighbours in the Hamptons or one of them lent the friend of another six figures to launch their wellness brand. In the case of myself and comedian Joanne McNally, it's that I'm fairly sure we gigged together in a caf on Brick Lane in London around seven years ago to approximately 12 people and a dog. Comedians have unshakable bonds as you come through the ranks based on how small, awful or weird a gig they did together was. Due to her stratospheric rise in the industry, I'm always a bit worried that I actually dreamt it and that it was someone else entirely, but when I open with it when we meet for this interview she confirms it was her. "Oh my god yes! I remember that!" She exclaims, and I'm thrilled I got it right, otherwise this would make for a fairly awkward start. She points out that we also did Latitude festival together in 2024, which makes me realise that in one extremely specific gig-to-gig trajectory, our careers are technically identical.

Joanne McNally is a phenomenon. I don't say that lightly. When I call her a rare breed of 'superstar comedian' in this interview she rebukes the idea, but if you're selling out arenas, have your own accessories line, a hit podcast with Vogue Williams, and manage to send every female friend I have into meltdown when I tell them I'm interviewing her, I think that status is earned. There are only a handful of comedians who get to a point in their career where whatever they do, people will buy into it, they're invested in them, they treat them as well as they would one of their best friends.

Other arena comedians, Micky Flanagan, Michael MacIntyre, John Bishop, are hugely successful, but go dark between tours, our insight into their lives are picked up and put down when they leave the stage. And of course, they're all middle-aged white guys (I love you Micky).

In Joanne's case, we feel like we're along with her on the journey and catching up with her when we watch her live, see her on social media or listen to her on *My Therapist Ghosted Me*, her podcast with pal Vogue Williams (model, podcaster, married to Spencer Matthews off of *Made In Chelsea*) which started in 2021 and by 2023 was already on a live tour around the UK, Ireland, Australia and even two shows in the US. Her fans wait for her takes on love, relationships, men, sex, marriage, kids, celebrity gossip, (my best friend bought data on her honeymoon in Thailand to listen to Joanne and Vogue's dissection of the recent Brooklyn Beckham saga) and everything in between. I've heard "that's what Joanne said" in conversation multiple times from people as if they know her personally when they don't, also assuming I'll know who they mean (by now I usually do) and it's this honesty that endears her to fans the world over. Throughout her career McNally has talked about adoption (she was born in Roscommon and adopted in Kiliney, a suburb of Dublin, and recently met her birth father), eating disorders (she received treatment for bulimia) and frequently talks about cosmetic procedures, relationships, and her personal life. As an ex-publicist, she's breaking the rules, letting people in on who she really is in what seems to be a very genuine and unguarded way, as well as knowing exactly what she's doing. "Is there anything you wouldn't talk about?" I ask her. "Oh god, yeah. Loads." I make supportive noises and think that's definitely a healthy way to do it, but McNally is so interesting that I want to be unprofessional and say, "What?! Tell me!?"

There is a great feeling that McNally's fans

"I broke up with a guy and he said, 'you just want to be single so you can write stand up about it'"



A woman with dark hair styled in a bun with some strands sticking out, sitting on a black stool against a solid pink background. She is wearing a white t-shirt, a bright yellow puffer jacket, and black pants. She is holding a black and white striped bag and wearing large black boots. She has multiple gold necklaces and large hoop earrings. The lighting is bright, casting a shadow of the stool on the pink floor.

“God bless podcasts! That’s all I can say. And I know everyone says the world is saturated with them, but I just don’t agree. Because I thought that when I started my podcast, I was like, ‘ah what’s the point?’ Do you know what I mean? But it’s changed my entire career”

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Top by Adidas, shorts by Adam Jones, bag by Anxious Preoccupied, jewellery by Tilly Sveaas, Edge of Ember, Celeste Starre and Joanne's own

are fun. Not too much fun, because there's no such thing. A friend who opened for the live show of *My Therapist Ghosted Me* in the north east of England said as he walked onto the stage, women were "hen do drunk" and having the time of their lives, even before the show had begun. Does McNally take this as a compliment? "Yes, massively so. Because I honestly think I'm the same. Game knows game, and I do feel like that's where I – without sounding like a complete wanker – do feel connected to them. I do feel like we're similar beasts. You know, we're mentally feral, physically groomed. Likely, you know, dopamine addicted with questionable drinking habits and a touch of undiagnosed ADHD." That explains why I loved your last tour, I tell her. She laughs. There's a feeling with McNally that you're finding out who you are as she finds out who she is in real time. There's therapy speak but it's not depressing, (even her accessories line is called *Anxious Preoccupied*, after her attachment style), analysing who you are through a chat with your mates, talking about how you react to things, realising what you want and talking about how to get it. Not to mention the ever-changing dating landscape that she's in again after breaking up with her last partner in 2024. I tell her I love the clips of her homing in on men in her audiences and asking them why they're there. "There were four straight men at my show in Portsmouth, and to this day, I still think about them. I have no idea why they're there, how they ended up there. I think maybe they thought it was a Joe Rogan show. I don't know. Maybe they misread the poster. What was all that about?" But she adds that her latest show *Pinotphile*, which she's mid-tour with now, has slightly more men than before. Her audience is growing with her.

So much of McNally's public identity is talking about the dating landscape as a successful woman in her early forties. Does she ever worry that marital bliss would provide a challenge on stage? "I broke up with one guy and he was going mad, he said

'You just want to be single so you can write stand up about it!' But no, I'm hoping that if that does come down the line that I'll still be able to write stand up about it because I'd love to have it. I'd love to have kids, I can write about that. I was really worried because *Prosecco* was about being single. *Pinotphile* is kind of accidentally about, it's painful, is more about female friendship. But when I started writing it, I was like uh-oh, I have nothing. I'm still here."

One of the reasons I think her podcast with Vogue is so popular, I say, is that between both of them you get the whole spectrum of the millennial woman experience. You have every stage of life wrapped up in these two people. Joanne is single without children (at the moment) and Vogue is married to a celebrity, lives in a big house and has three children. Vogue barely drinks, Joanne has named three shows to date around boozing (*Wine Tamer*, *The Prosecco Express*, and current show *Pinotphile*) and has her own rituals around it. Single woman Sundays, McNally's church that she preaches via her Instagram stories, usually includes a chicken caesar salad, a large glass of white wine and the Sunday papers (bliss). Joanne and Vogue had technically been pally for years, being part of a bigger gang in Dublin back in the day, but never really getting to know each other that well. Then, when McNally started gigging more in London and moved over, Vogue offered her a place to stay. It's always talked of as "Joanne was staying in Vogue's basement" but as Joanne says, "when I say basement, we're not talking Fritzl style. We're talking... stunning, you know? But I like leaning into the fact that I was living under her stairs." The two became proper friends, as I guess you'd have to in such close quarters, and Vogue suggested they do a podcast together. The rest is not just history, but became life changing. In less than five years, *My Therapist Ghosted Me* has enabled both women to cultivate their own careers and shaped the path they're both on now. It must be very freeing not to have to follow

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the same path as 99% of comedians before her have had to. Write a show, bankrupt yourself taking it to the Fringe, tour it if you can, do circuit gigs to pay the bills, hope for an appearance on a panel show or the Apollo, and repeat. "God bless podcasts! That's all I can say. And I know everyone says the world is saturated with them, but I just don't agree. Because I thought that when I started my podcast, I was like, 'ah what's the point?' Do you know what I mean? But it's changed my entire career." I tell her that based on seeing her say this exact thing on Mo Gilligan's podcast, I agreed to do an audio series (OK fine A PODCAST!) with a friend just today. She's glad. "I haven't heard of anyone selling less tickets because they do a podcast. I do feel like with the TV side of things, I wasn't like a darling of the panel shows or anything like that. I'm not sure the format really suits me, to be honest. So I was like, how am I going to do this?"

Doing things her own way is a recurring theme throughout our chat together and, without sounding too American here, it's inspiring. Every industry is changing but the comedy world can still feel like there's doors shut to you depending on factors outside of your control, whether or not you know that commissioner, how well your show was reviewed by a broadsheet that never would've gone for you anyway. Thanks to the podcast, social media, and having years of gigging to back it up, McNally has done one of the biggest tours of any Irish comedian ever, all whilst barely gracing mainstream TV screens. She recently announced a record-breaking 10th date at London's iconic Hammersmith Apollo. That's nearly 40,000 tickets for one venue in London alone, and 2026 sees her heading out to sell-out shows in Australia, New Zealand and across the USA. And some people don't like it. I ask her about her mammoth show *The Prosecco Express*, a show about your friends going through life's milestones, all of which involve celebrating with a glass of the fizzy stuff, whilst she'd moved home to her mum's attic

after a break up, and had started using adult colouring books. The show began in 2019 at the Fringe and it's final performance was in Dublin in January 2024. She performed the sold out show a record-breaking 78 times at Dublin's iconic Vicar Street venue. The appeal for it was almost endless. I ask her about this, performing the same show for so long, and she said she's thrilled she got to, despite some snobbery from other people asking her why she was still doing it. "Because it was selling," she replied. McNally is driven, but by her own goals, not by what she should be seen to be doing.

She's come a long way even from a fancy basement now, I'm talking to McNally today over Zoom, me in my living room in London, her in a swanky hotel in Cork, mid six-night run of her current tour show *Pinotphile*. You're used to seeing her in nice surroundings though, I tell her that her flat in south London she's rented for two years now is almost as famous as her. It's been shot for the *Irish Independent* and regularly features on her social media, often telling fans where she got everything and where they can find the same (I'm guilty of DMing her last year to ask where she got an incredible wavy mirror, she didn't just tell me where, but also how to get it for a bargain price).

I pluck up the courage to ask Joanne something as a woman in the same sphere as myself, but with a much bigger following, "Is there ever a point where you feel totally fine saying no to things?" It's something I know must happen at one point, but at what stage does the panic of paying the rent as any type of freelancer, elude you? She answers instantly "Oh yeah, all the time. I've never been financially motivated. I'm no communist or anything, I like having an income, but my background as a publicist means I've always sort of known where I want to be seen and where I don't. Obviously I want to be in *Ralph*." She's right as well, I'm having a flashback to try to book her for a lucrative Zoom gig over lockdown for a

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Top by Robyn Lynch, jewellery by Tilly Sveaas, Edge of Ember, Celeste Starle and Joanne's own

“I've always wanted to go large with my stand up career”

private members club. McNally is a woman of principles, and it's this combined with her honesty about her struggles, her opinions, and her life that make her so brilliant. When we gigged together at the aforementioned Latitude in 2024, we both did so having pulled out and then been rebooked again once Barclays were dropped as a sponsor of the event. This just made me love her even more. You can be principled, even if you're not overtly political.

Playing such huge venues, for so long, and with so many people's expectations on you could really start to get to you. How does she cope? “I think, for whatever reason, I'm pretty good at rolling with the punches. I'm not particularly sentimental. I'm not doing a Timothée Chalamet thing where I'm looking for greatness. I've always wanted to go large with my stand-up career. I'm 10 years in. It feels like I haven't had a pinch me moment yet. Maybe that would be if Tina Fey takes me for something! Don't get me wrong, I'm pleased I can sell and tour and travel around, but if you think about it too much... you never want to be that person who's drunk their own Kool-Aid and disappeared up their own hole. The key to never doing that is to not really think about anything. Just don't think about anything. Just bottle it all up.

That's my advice!” She laughs. I take note, comedians are well-known for having time on their own on the road to overthink absolutely everything. Maybe this is another area she has conquered with her own wisdom.

Joanne McNally's therapist may have ghosted her (yes, that's where it comes from) but she's unknowingly paying it forward, and that's what makes her so successful. She's your straight-talking friend who tells you to pack it in or to dump him, all whilst cracking you up. She's one of us, and she's also just really sound. That's what it boils down to. She's ambitious without being clinical about it (almost spitting her drink out when I ask her if she's the Irish Rihanna), she's writing about what she's going through for as many of us that want to hear it, and she's having a rest in her gorgeous apartment when she needs it. I ask her what's next and she says she's touring for the rest of the year and then “Who knows?” I like that she doesn't know. It could be anything. Whatever it is, it won't be boring. Despite me interviewing her, I've come away feeling refreshed, motivated, unashamed of trying a new podcast, and I just turned down a gig that would've been a waste of time. I feel like she should bill me for the hour. Are we friends now? Is she my therapist now? I hope she doesn't ghost me. *ralph*

A black and white photograph of a musician playing a guitar. In the foreground, a red surface holds a handwritten note that reads: "NEW SONGS", "boy boy", "money", "billy", "11 way", "ST L". The musician is in the background, focused on playing the guitar.

What made the post-Strokes New York music scene feel like living in a brave new world?

Words by Cameron Cook
Photos by Abbey Braden Raymonde

Words by Cameron Cook
Photos by Abbey Braden Raymonde

A photograph of a neon sign for a pizzeria. The sign features the words "NEW YORK" in large, green, block letters at the top, and "SLICES" in large, red, block letters below it. To the left of "NEW YORK", the words "George's Pizzeria" are written in a smaller, green, cursive script. The sign is mounted on a dark background, and a small, glowing red "EXIT" sign is visible to the left of the main sign.

When I was 16, I saw Cameron Crowe's semi-autobiographical rock drama Almost Famous in the theatre. I was already obsessed with music at that point – I stayed up until 2am on school nights to watch obscure indie video blocks on MTV2, and scraped my meagre pennies together to buy one solitary concert ticket a month. While initially mesmerised by Billy Crudup's skintight Wranglers and Kate Hudson's Afghan coat, as the film progressed, I zeroed in on Patrick Fugit's character: the pimply, awkward, teenage virgin William, who hustles his way into an assignment following one of his favourite bands on tour for Rolling Stone. As I left the showing, I stared into Kate's moon-shaped sunglasses on the movie's gigantic poster. "Hey!" I thought, "I could do that." I already knew I could write, and finding a group of drunk 20-something musicians to hang around couldn't be that difficult. Rock stars, I pondered, are notoriously egotistical, so they would probably talk to me if I asked, even if I was myself also a pimply, awkward, teenage virgin. On top of that, my name's also Cameron, and I'm gay, which made me inherently more interesting than Cameron Crowe. Life vocation unlocked. I have this in the bag.

It's with this level of delusional confidence that a few years later, in the fall of 2002, I moved to New York City as a high school graduate with zero intentions of pursuing a college degree, and every intention of strong-arming my way into every dilapidated greenroom in every tiny venue on the Lower East Side. In the two years between my cinematic epiphany and my arrival to "the city" (as I soon learned everyone called

New York City), The Strokes had become a household name, every music publication and record label were falling over themselves trying to snatch up 'New York's Next Big Thing'. The Yeah Yeah Yeahs had made art-punk cool again, a decade after grunge's post-metal rockist macho posturing had invaded the airwaves (and they didn't even have a bassist). The Moldy Peaches wore children's Halloween costumes and sang songs about drugs and pornography, and the freak folk scene bloomed around their wacko sets at the Sidewalk Café. You could leave your apartment and walk up to any of the seemingly hundreds of live music venues that dotted Lower Manhattan – the Mercury Lounge, the Bowery Ballroom, Sin-é, Piano's, Arlene's Grocery, Tonic, Lit, Luna Lounge, the Knitting Factory – and see something incredible, or at least strange enough that you'd remember it probably for the rest of your life. Across the East River, in the barely tamed wilderness of Williamsburg, ex-club-kid DJ Larry Tee had started a party at a dive bar called Luxx and named it Berliniamsburg, coined the phrase "electroclash", and suddenly everyone was sporting asymmetrical mullets and buying Roland samplers off eBay. There was a lot of bad stuff, and weird stuff, but there was much, much more good stuff, and it was cheap and accessible. Everyone was doing everything.

I would walk down Houston in the middle of the afternoon and jot down names of bands that seemed interesting off of flyers Scotch-taped to lampposts, check out their websites, and cold email them: Your band is rad, can I interview you? As I had suspected, everyone said yes. At this point I had a blog with a modest following, and an electroclash band I had befriended called Mommy and Daddy introduced me to Marisa Brickman, the editor-in-chief of a magazine called 'SUP, who started a music zine in college because she hated her school's newspaper. Although I wasn't getting paid, had barely any source of income, and no professional prospects, I



The Long Blondes @ Studio B



Lissy Trullie @ Lit Lounge



Gossip @ The Knitting Factory



Penguin Prison



No Age @ Warsaw



Vivian Girls



The Pains of Being Pure at Heart @ The Knitting Factory



CSS

felt in my bones that my plan was in motion. My age worked to my advantage. I was everyone's nerdy, outgoing, so-uncool-he's-kind-of-cool little brother who was as excited about their music as they were – sometimes even a little bit more. Eventually, 'SUP got me a part-time job working the mail room at Mute Records, which I gladly took because I was beyond desperate, and I could meet Andy Bell from Erasure.

Back in the early-to-mid 2000s, most music was still being listened to on CD, so record labels needed robust mailrooms to service their releases to radio stations and journalists. Now a legitimate journalist myself, I received dozens of mailers a week stuffed with new music, usually still unavailable to the masses, as well as guestlist spots to whoever I wanted to see just for asking – literally a dream come true. I thought I had hit the jackpot. One of these promo records I received was a compilation called *NY: The Next Wave*, from a label called Kanine Records. Based in Brooklyn, Kanine is run by husband/wife duo Lio and Kay Cerezo, and were responsible for some of the era's most iconic NYC releases. They released the first Grizzly Bear album, discovered Caroline Polachek and her band Chairlift, and put out *The Pains of Being Pure at Heart*-adjacent bands like *The Depreciation Guild* and *The Natvral* (more on those characters later). Lio, under the name DJ Oil, also threw a weekly party called *Crashin' In*, which meandered around Brooklyn through a plethora of venues, hosting live music nights of everyone you would want to see. When I got my hands on *NY: The Next Wave*, it was like I was thrust into the world I had been seeking for so long – the music was so fresh, so varied and so good. And everyone who made it lived within easy walking distance of my (dilapidated) apartment.

I asked Lio what made him move to NYC from Atlanta in 2000. "It was one night around 3:30am as I was walking through Tompkins Square Park," he said, of a trip he took to

the city around that time. "I had just gone out that night to see some live bands: The Walkmen and Radio 4, and then stopped by Beauty Bar to hear the DJ play cool songs by rock bands – not house music.

He was playing The Modern Lovers, Television, Blondie, Dead Boys, etc. As I was walking through the park I stopped, looked up at the moon and said, 'Something is really happening here and I need to be a part of it.' I never felt so alive in my life." Hearing him describe this, I could also feel, smell, taste what those late nights in Manhattan were to me too. I often wonder if it's just nostalgia for youth that makes me feel that way. If I had moved to London, or Berlin, LA or Chicago, would I also remember those cities through a haze of warmth and wonder?

"New York's very different now," says Lio when I ask him if he still feels the same way about the scene as he did back in the day. "In the early '00s, the scene was all based around the Lower East Side of Manhattan, and the music scene and community was very small and tight. There was really only one main show a week, and everyone went. And if you didn't, you strongly felt like you missed out on something. Now, since the cost of living is so high, everyone has moved far out of Manhattan. A scene is stronger when it is small and moves together. Now you have scenes in The Bronx, Ridgewood, Bushwick, Williamsburg. With that happening, there are too many great shows happening every night. Too many clubs, venues, and bands. There isn't a strong sense of priority. But the struggle to make it is still there."

This explosion into the outer boroughs had already begun by the time I entered my mid-20s. I skipped around Harlem, the Bronx, Washington Heights and Greenpoint, going out several nights a week to see bands. My friend Kristina, who I met on an NYC music fan page on Livejournal, lived in a sixth-floor walk-up above her grandparents' restaurant in Chinatown and had become my late-

night partner in crime. Her apartment had a washer-dryer, so as far as I was concerned she was upper class. One day, perusing MySpace on her couch, I noticed that our friends Kip and Alex had added us via a page for a band called *The Pains of Being Pure at Heart*. Cool name. Alex had gone to college with Kristina and we both thought he was cute. "Kip and Alex are in a band?" I said casually as I pressed play on the media player. Wait, this is really good. A wave of indie-pop-jangly, catchy, fuzzy guitar tunes with introspective lyrics was beginning to take over the city with bands like *Crystal Stilts* and *Vivian Girls*, and *Pains* soon found themselves cresting that swell. They became our gang's house band. They thanked Kris and I in the liner notes of their debut album, which made us absolutely giddy. They headlined my 23rd birthday party at the Knitting Factory's old TriBeCa location, and to this day it's one of the most memorable birthdays I've ever had (extremely long story short, early '90s hip-hop act P.M. Dawn were playing next door, and they crashed the party, got trashed and told me to "never give up on my dreams" – which, to their credit, I never have).

Connecting with Kip, he reminded me of another venue we used to spend all our time at, *Cake Shop*, which existed somewhere in the Bermuda Triangle of Piano's, Orchard Bar, and San Loco. "It was a tiny basement venue on Ludlow Street," says Kip. "It was almost like a clubhouse for us. Andy Bodor, who ran it, didn't really seem too concerned about running a profitable business, and he'd just book bands he liked, regardless if anyone came to the show. We'd play there all the time to the same 12 people, with bands like *Crystal Stilts*, *The Besties*, *My Teenage Stride*, etc. Some of the punker bands like *Vivian Girls*, *Woods*, and *Titus Andronicus* usually played *Death by Audio*, *Shea Stadium* and the other Todd P [extremely prolific promoter] venues, which were really cool too – but for whatever reason, we were a *Cake Shop* band, that was our spot." He tells me about the time that, for their

second anniversary, *Cake Shop* booked a brand new band called *Vampire Weekend* to go on first. I had already heard of them by that point, because all my older goth friends were pissed that they had the word "vampire" in their name but wore polo shirts and boat shoes. "Andy Bodor, who owned *Cake Shop*, had them opening for *German Measles* and *caUSE co-MOTION!* I remember being there early and liking their set a lot, I mean, they were actually really incredible. But Andy was laughing about it after they played, and told me he knew they were going to be huge, but he thought it was funny to make them open for *German Measles*. I mean, hats off to them, they seemed to be pretty good natured about opening for a band that rhymed "drinking Sparks" with "Central Park" and (probably) getting paid like, \$60."

We also reminisce about one of our most mutually beloved bands, *My Favorite*, who I first discovered on the *NY: The Next Wave* compilation and are probably the most underrated band of the entire decade. "Peggy [Pains' keyboardist/vocalist] and I adored this hyper-melancholic marxist new wave band called *My Favorite*. I mean, just describing them like that makes me kind of laugh a little—they were like if OMD was from Long Island. They were both ahead of, and behind their time. Michael Grace Jr., the frontman, wrote these aching, coming-of-age pop songs about class war and the 1980s. They were unlike anything that was happening around them, and because they were a scene of one, I don't think they ever really caught on in a bigger way. But for Peggy and I, they were the coolest."

These days, maybe a "scene of one" is what we should be striving for. I've been wondering for years if scenes are even still relevant. I left New York 10 years ago for Berlin, where bands are virtually non-existent and literally 50% of the under-40 population are DJs. Lio and Kip are still somewhat

connected to NYC, although we're all 20 years older and don't go out as much (they are both dads, I'm still gay). Speaking to both of them though, I have a newfound hope for New York, and music in general. If we did it back in the day, started bands and magazines and record labels, surely kids these days with the embarrassment of options at their fingertips, could figure out how to make some cool shit.

"There's always people coming and making cool stuff and existing in places and in new ways," Kip says about the New York scene in 2026. "Some people mourn CBGB, others mourn Brownies, Death by Audio, Glasslands or 285 Kent – and I mourn Cake Shop. But the spirit that animated those places is inextinguishable. There will always be young people who come to the city and, against kinda overwhelming odds, try to make a cool thing happen. I was once one of them. But now I see people like Shannon McMahon doing college radio, throwing parties and doing a great 'zine called *My Little Underground*, or Lex Walton hosting these cozy DIY house shows with both older artists like Kleenex Girl Wonder and newer ones like Matthew Danger Lippman, and I know that it's gotta be just the tip of the iceberg. There's so much good stuff happening in New York, if you just look for it."

"But it was truly a perfect time and place for music," says Lio. "It's gone, but never forgotten." *ralph*



TV On The Radio @ Union Pool



Crowd at Matt&Kim @ Fordham



Sam Champion @ Rothko



Peaches @ Tribeca Grand



The Virgins @ Studio B



French Kicks @ Sin-E



Surfer Blood



Liars @ Warsaw

DISPATCH #7 - KINOSAKI ONSEN



Ralph's Food & Drink Editor and sandwich pioneer, Max Halley, is missing in Mexico so we asked our globe-trotting resident boozehound, Gav Murphy to step in and get gastronomic for us

“Returning to the same place isn’t repetition, it’s a revelation! The map stays the same, but you arrive as someone new, especially if you’re sexy and Welsh, like Gav.” – Max Halley

For a childless Welshman in his forties, who plays with toys for a living and has no hope of getting a mortgage anytime soon, jumping on a plane and heading to a different country to eat and drink around the place is essentially my main hobby. If I’m not gobbing off on YouTube or on some podcast about computer games, then you’ll usually find me filling that same gob with some kind of beautiful feast in another part of the world.

Welsh people, in their bones, are creatures of habit though, and while many people shit on the concept of going to the same city or even country twice, I’m a firm believer that revisiting places is always a good idea. That familiarity doesn’t ever dull an experience – it sharpens it! And so it was, that I headed back to Japan for a fifth time, because the returning traveller doesn’t rush to the same haunts that tourists flock to after a dead-eyed influencer told them that a certain little bakery does the best nikumans in Tokyo, oh no! The reacquainting voyager walks familiar, well-trodden streets with a leisurely air. At least that’s what I tell myself when I duck into the same bar in Osaka where I once got a really frosty lager in that cured my jet lag.

I’ve been lucky enough to visit the big box-ticking places of Japan a few times for work and other nonsense, so when I arrived this time I jumped on the Shinkansen – otherwise known as the bullet train – from Tokyo and headed north to a little town called Kinosaki Onsen. While the stupidly rapid train is very fun, the best part of the journey is the snack huts on the station. They sell these magical lunch boxes that would make anyone who’s ever bought a Pret quiver with rage. Pair these bento boxes with a cheap little

Japanese lager at 11am, and turn any ride into a full-on magical journey.

A monk founded Kinosaki Onsen 1300 years ago, when he discovered healing spring waters, and now it’s home to a lovely bunch of hot spring bath houses (all tattoo-friendly, if you’re that way inclined) [ooooof - Ed] that sit on a stunning willow-lined canal. Visitors can hop in the baths throughout the day in between stepping into the cutest little restaurants and bars. During a particularly dusky jet lag stroll around town, I stumbled into the luminously inviting *Nogani BBQ Seafood Skewers*. Immediately drawn to the various grilled meats on show – the octopus and shrimp being the highlight – the best part of the visit was the beer. Look, I know Suntory’s Premium Malts is a pretty standard beer in Japan, but this place served the coldest lager in the frostiest glass I’d ever seen. My lovely, patient partner caught me sighing after I took a sip and asked me what was wrong. My reply was “I’m just so fuckin’ happy with our decisions.”

I treated myself to a few skewers as a sort of early-dinner starter because I was already booked into a special beef restaurant where the fellas running it are just obsessed with serving up cow in the best way possible. The chefs buy cows that have been raised like kings and turn them into a set menu where even the soup and the salad courses are packed with beefy goodness. If that wasn’t enough, they even have their own red ale made in house, which has a big red sticker on it that says “RED BEER FOR BEEF” and tastes like a thick, crisp glass of gold.

I was eager to repeat this monumentally successful first day in the town, so with a booking at one of the most sought after restaurants in town secured, I headed in search of some pre-dinner swigs. And Lord! Did I find the perfect place in a tiny little bottle shop called Teratani, which is



“Winter in this part of Japan means one thing: massive snow crabs”



**“Pair these
Bento boxes with
a cheap little
Japanese lager
at 11am, and turn
any ride into a
full-on magical
journey”**



brimming with various saké and wine, but more importantly a local Kinosaki beer on tap, which is made by the perfectly named brewery: Gubi Gabu. They make four different styles including a 6% “Crab Beer”, which I asked the fantastic gent working the bar if it “had any crab in” to thunderous laughter. I can’t believe he’s never been asked that before, but if he had, he’s maybe the most generous audience member on the planet for shit jokes. I bought a pint and he poured himself the tiniest little plastic cup of beer to join me in a teeny toast. We tried to butcher our way through a conversation about pints in our broken version of the other’s language before we gave up and he just walked me around the shop pointing at beers he liked in silence. It was heaven. On my way out, he gifted me a shirt which had a pencil drawing of himself on it and insisted on posing for me with it as I took a photo. Well, I say “gifted” but, as I write this, I actually can’t be sure if he did give it to me as a present or if he was just showing it to me, and then was too polite to stop me as I thanked him

profusely and walked out with the shirt under my arms.

As well as ending my time at Kinosaki Onsen as potentially a suspect at large, I also decided to finish my visit with a traditional gigantic-coursed kaiseki dinner at Nishimuraya Honkan – one of the swankiest hotels in the sleepest part of town. The chefs offer a strict menu based on the season and I’d come as their winter menu was in full swing. Winter in this part of Japan means one thing: fuckin’ massive snow crabs. The chefs here are experts in preparing this tricky animal either on the grill, in a little miniature hot pot or even just straight up raw. They pair the fluffiest crab with the juiciest local beef and the result is a tasting menu that I think about every time I now eat Japanese food. The little sashimi dish with snow crab served up three ways has now spoiled sashimi for me until the end of time. Or until I return again... unless I am now a wanted criminal in Kinosaki Onsen for drunkenly stealing some booze merch. *ralph*

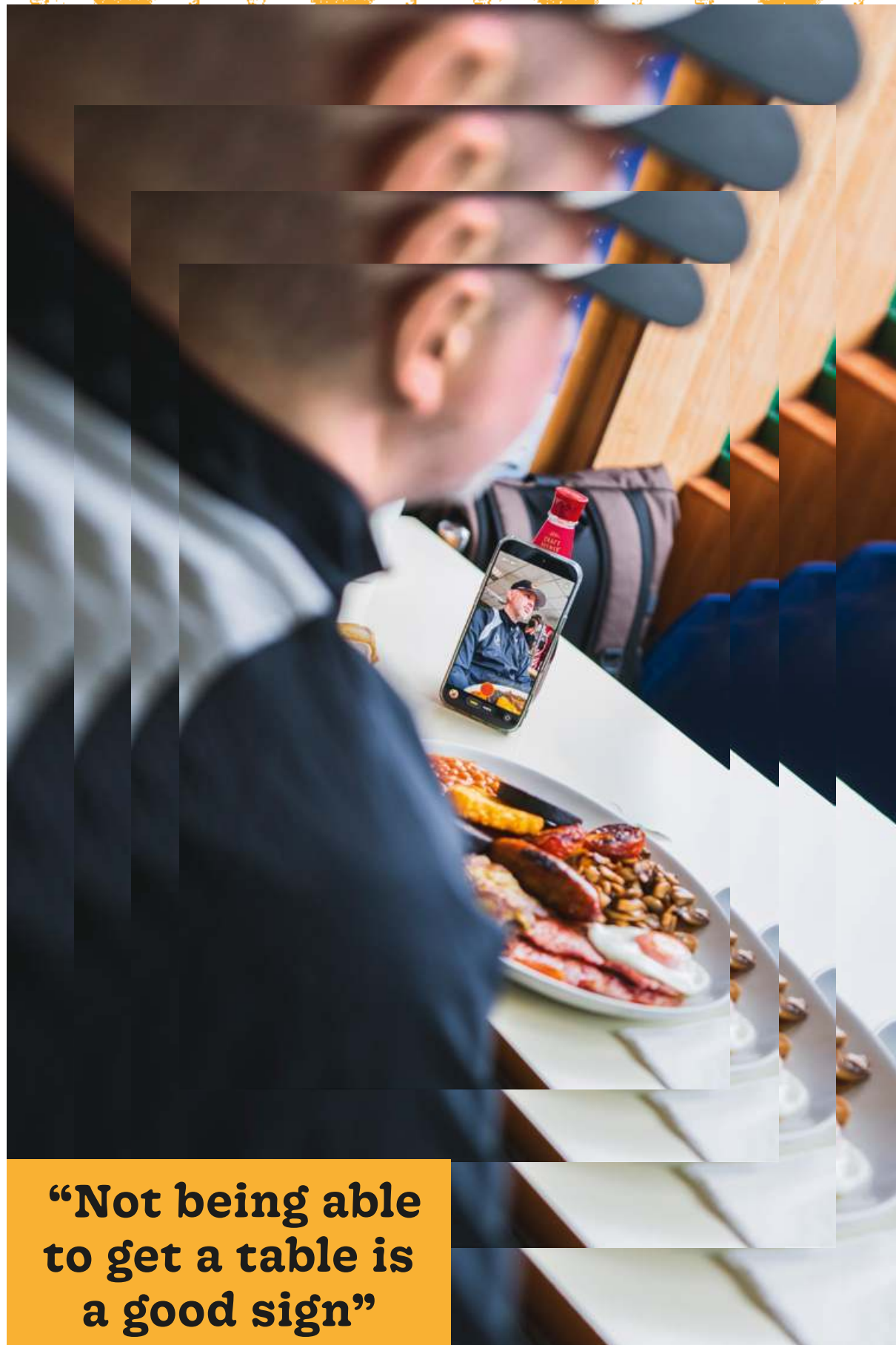
YOU GOTTA



The man on a mission to eat a fry up
at every greasy spoon in London



Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by Aiyush Pachnanda



“Not being able to get a table is a good sign”

James Dimitri knows his way around a full English. “I don’t like that a lot of places drop black pudding these days” he tells me as he tucks into his breakfast. We’re chatting at the Ritz Cafe in Hammersmith. Around us, the hustle and bustle of one of London’s iconic greasy spoons fills the air. “It needs to have a lively, busy atmosphere,” he says, glancing around. The sizzle of bacon cuts through the hum of the packed room. “Not being able to get a table is a good sign” Dimitri ruminates. He should know.

Food is built into his very fabric. “When my grandad moved over from Cyprus, he worked as the head waiter at Simpson’s in the Strand, a really old school restaurant at the Savoy Hotel. He then worked at Talk of the Town, which is now the Hippodrome Casino but used to be this big Cabaret type thing with Sammy Davis Jr. and Bruce Forsyth performing while people ate their dinner.”

“Even though he was Cypriot, he loved old British food,” he adds. “Prawn cocktail and a glass of Chablis!” James inherited that love of food, which he also attributes to his grandmother’s cooking.

After graduating university, James found himself working at Harrods Food Halls. “My job was doing the food shop for rich people, packing it up and sending it off,” he tells me as his breakfast starts to disappear. “I used to do Mohamed Al-Fayed’s food shop for him. We’d see people order a bottle of whiskey worth £45,000, or have to put a bottle of Cristal in the back of a black cab and off to someone’s house. I even once sent a trolley full of whole foie gras stomachs to the Bin Laden family...”

It was around this time, in 2012, that the food scene in London really began to explode. “There were all these street food things

like Kerb. Places like Bleecker Burger. Stuff popping up all the time that people got excited for.” And it was also around this time that Dimitri started documenting food.

Over the past decade and a half, he’s built a huge online following. Over 250,000 people follow his Instagram channel where he regularly posts reviews of meals and guides to eating in cities across the world. One of his most popular series is his mission to visit every greasy spoon in London. When we met he had visited 122, with more lined up in his meticulously planned calendar.

“When I was younger, and travelling abroad for months in South-East Asia, the thing I would miss the most would be a full English breakfast,” he recounts when I asked him about the inspiration behind the series. “I like old places,” he adds. “places that are trapped in time. Take this place [Ritz Cafe], it has a great community feel. The owner knows all the locals when they come in. It’s always really friendly. It feels like an older London. It’s why I love the pie and mash shops as well. Like it’s not an exciting dish at all, but some of the shops are so beautiful and the characters in there are so captivating, you feel like you’re eating in the past.”

He is, according to his own estimations, the person who has eaten in more greasy spoons than anyone else. “I don’t think many people will go out of their way to do a three-hour round trip for a breakfast, so I think I can say that!” he laughs.

Beyond black pudding – traditionally made with pigs blood, fat, oatmeal and herbs – and a good buzzing atmosphere, I ask him what are his key ingredients for a perfect full English breakfast. “I always prefer a proper sausage over a deep fried cheap catering sausage, and I always look out for the beans to see if they’re cooked down or if there is loads of bean juice as well.”

The contents of the full English plate, it turns

out, are a heavily contested space. "A lot of people are traditionally very anti-hash browns on a plate, but they've been part of a breakfast since the '80s. It's been 45 years, so it's probably time to get over it. Same with chips." Dimitri adds, revelling in his brutal dispatch. "It's ridiculous. You even get some people moaning saying beans shouldn't be part of a fry up because they're originally American, but they've been part of a full English since the 1920's so there is no one alive today eating it that can remember a time before them"

James hasn't just stopped at English breakfasts though. His latest series has seen him trying, and rating, breakfasts of different cultures at cafés across London. "There is a Somalian spot near me and I wanted to check out the breakfast, so I thought, maybe I'll start doing a ranking thing for it as well," he tells me of the genesis of the series. What's the best he's had? I ask. "I had a Scottish breakfast at the Auld Hag in Angel, Islington yesterday that was amazing and I can't forget a Malaysian breakfast I had recently – roti canai, the bread just with the curry sauce – it was unreal. It reminded me of travelling in Singapore and Malaysia." With the good must, of course, come the bad. Before I'd even finished asking him about the worst breakfast he'd tried he cut me off, "I hate Japanese breakfast. Grilled mackerel with rice and miso soup just isn't what I want to eat for breakfast."

Dimitri is as sardonic in person as he is online, and takes no prisoners when it comes to replying to his commenters on social media. "I think it's why a lot of people find me entertaining," he says when I ask him about his combative online style. "I have quite a low threshold for stupid comments, and if I don't agree with something, whether it's online or in person, I will always say so. People love it when I have an argument." But what's the most ridiculous clash he's ever had online? "I always get people telling me I can't use the knife and fork properly because I hold it in a specific way to show to the camera. Just today someone said 'it gives me the ick when grown adults can't



"I've been to 120 greasy spoons and someone will comment telling me to go to Regency Cafe. That's like telling a New Yorker to go to Katz's Deli!"

use a knife and fork' and like, I'm literally doing it to show the items to the camera!" He laughs half in exasperation. "It also really grates on me when I say in the reel 'I've been to 120 greasy spoons' and someone will comment underneath telling me I need to go to Regency Cafe. That's like telling a lifelong New Yorker to go to Katz's Deli!"

It's not all bad though. Earlier, as we sat down, and before I even got a chance to ask a single question, someone leaned over from a neighbouring table to tell him they'd found the café through one of his guides to eating in the city. "It happens all the time," he says when I later ask him about it. "If I walk into any pub in Soho, I get recognised. I like it! It's good if you're by yourself as well, going for a drink and then you just start chatting with people."

James isn't your usual food influencer (he'd probably hate to even be called that). Disarmingly lo-fi, he does his filming with just a phone leant up against a condiment bottle while he eats – no ring lights on tripods, telling people not to get in his shot or asking for free meals. Even with his enormous audience, documenting food isn't actually James' full time hustle. "I've worked for

Californian tech companies for 15 years," he tells me. "My job is flexible and I travel loads with the job, which goes hand in hand with my food blogging." For James, there is no desire to make it any more than "a hobby".

"I'm just happy with it growing as it is," he explains. "I've started to get cooler invites. I had one invitation to go to India and visit a bunch of places but I couldn't do it because my second kid is about to be born." He has turned down almost all paid collaborations, with the exception of HP Sauce, which "was a natural fit because I plug it all the time anyway!" To make it big, he reckons, you have to "completely sell out." And that seems like an unlikely path for James to take.

The day after we meet, he texts me, fleshing out his thoughts on the contents of a fry up – in particular, the need for beans to never be served in a ramekin. Beneath it all, this is a man that just fundamentally loves breakfast. He loves eating it. Loves talking about it. Loves filming it and exploring it. And rating it. But in the end, it all comes back to one man and one massive plate of morning food.

What a life! *ralph*



JAMES DIMITRI'S FULL ENGLISH REQUIREMENTS

**BEANS MUST
BE JUICY
AND NOT
SERVED IN A
RAMEKIN**

**BUTTON
MUSHROOMS,
NEVER
PORTOBELLO
(TOO PONCEY)**

**THE TOMATO
SHOULD BE
COOKED UNTIL
IT IS CHARRED
AND FALLING
APART**

**CHIPS
AND HASH
BROWNS ARE
FINE
– GROW UP!**

**THE VIBES
MUST BE
IMMACULATE**

**SAUSAGES SHOULD BE GOOD
AND REAL AND NOT DEEP
FRIED CATERING SAUSAGES**



MAX
MAX
MAX
MAX
MAX

MAX

HEADROOM
HAS A
VIRUS

Words by Ralph Jones
Illustration by James-Lee Duffy

Max Headroom, holding a vape and looking squarely at the ground, blew a candy-floss-flavoured cloud from his downturned mouth. His once-blonde hair is the colour of smoke now, his face beginning to crease with wrinkles. He was at Excel London ostensibly to promote his memoir, I Told You So, You Idiots. His management had committed him to a 38-date tour. They intended it, they said, to be his reintroduction to a world he had all but left behind. But that day in east London he was out of sorts, barking and snapping at people, complaining about how much everything smelled. He was the victim of an ailment that afflicts all manner of digital devices, from big to small. But for Max Headroom, this ailment meant a fundamental threat to the very fabric of himself; a threat so dangerous he couldn't be totally sure he would make it out alive. Max Headroom had a virus.

Max Headroom with a virus is Sinatra without song, Beckham without balls. For a man powered by artificial intelligence, a virus has the makings of an existential catastrophe. As surely as it destabilised Headroom, it sent the people around him into a tailspin. The virus was the cat amongst the pigeons; the gust of wind on the tightrope which at any moment had the potential to send Headroom and his coterie of admirers sailing 100 storeys down, down, down.

But first, the tour.

Max Headroom put his vape back into the pocket of his suit and cleared his throat. He lowered his sunglasses and noticed that someone was trying to catch his attention. "Not right now, sorry," he said to a young woman. She held in her hand a photo of him as a much younger man. He was under strict instruction from his management and publishers not to sign anything but the copies of the book he was there to sell. There was

a faraway look, perhaps a look of yearning, as Headroom took in the photo of himself, frozen in time at the height of his fame. He disappeared through the door.

Inside, Headroom was preparing for another interview about his time in the spotlight. Hand in his pocket, still clutching the vape, he rounded a corner and stalked down yet another of the convention centre's anonymous corridors. Three paces behind him, as he invariably was, walked Roland Fenugreek, who for the last ten years has been Headroom's right-hand man. Fenugreek, like everyone who dotes on Headroom, must reckon with the fact that he is a human man working for a being made of artificial intelligence.

"How are you feeling?" Fenugreek said, his little legs struggling to keep up with Headroom. That day he wore a pinstriped suit and a bow tie the colour of a Werther's Original.

"Goddamn b-b-b-b-bug," said Headroom, his synthetic voice rising and falling in that inimitable fashion. "I gotta visit the little boys' room." He then threw his head back and emitted a range of strangulated, high-pitched cries – a side effect of the virus.

Fenugreek, iPad in hand, wondered if professional obligation meant he ought to follow Headroom to the bathroom. He followed Headroom to the bathroom.

Whether or not Max Headroom's brand of bombastic irony was for you, you couldn't ignore him during a spell in the mid-1980s. His face was all over Channel 4; talk shows from Wogan to Letterman; he was even the face of Coca-Cola, appearing with Michael Jordan in adverts directed by Ridley Scott. Wherever you looked, there was Headroom, helping you navigate a confusing world. His face was on magazine covers; he was endlessly imitated; he was a cyber personality long before AI had infiltrated popular culture.





And Headroom wasn't just ubiquitous. He captivated a generation of people like a cult leader. His sly take on popular culture, eery in its prescience, turned him into something close to a prophet. But, after the veejaying on Channel 4, the eponymous film, the magazine covers, the TV series on ABC, he faded into the background of our lives; perhaps even his own life. He sold his home in Malibu to an influencer. He retreated to a cabin in the forest. He moved on and moved away. He became a memory.

It is difficult to watch icons grow old, for we are reminded that we too are defenceless against the cruelties of time. But just as anything made up of skin and blood gets old, so too did Headroom. Two days before that day in east London he had turned 41. Like a movie star held together by fillers and fixes, he was a patchwork of digital updates and upgrades. Should Max Headroom have lived this long? It was a question even he asked himself.

His ex-wife will tell you that something cracked in Headroom; that he turned away from a world he saw turning sour. Minnie Headroom lives in a huge villa in Los Angeles. She plays golf. She sculpts. She can no longer bear to speak to her ex-husband. "He can

see the future," she said. "I can't be around that any more. Once I liked it; I found it fascinating, I guess. Now the future looks so bad, I don't... I don't want to know what's coming."

It must be terrifying for a man to see, so brightly and so clearly, the pitfalls and downfalls of the years to come. Perhaps this was what drove Headroom out of the limelight – that he expected Trump; that he knew Brexit was coming. It may not be a coincidence that he went to ground before the coronavirus upended the world. There are some who believe that he was driven mad, unable to bear the heavy burden of a man who saw the future. No, turn that word around – who was the future. There are many who believe that his vision can only mean that he owed us more.

Roland Fenugreek will tell you that his hero feared for his own safety; that Headroom had become paranoid about Channel 4 watching his house; that he insisted there were microphones in his eyes. Headroom's daughter, Lexi, now 22, will tell you that he had grown tired of the countless parodies of himself which popped up incessantly, like bubbles in a saucepan of simmering soup. There are as many explanations for

Headroom's disappearance as there are transistors in his body. Perhaps none of them is true. Perhaps, somehow, all of them are.

If Max Headroom disappeared out of the limelight, why did he come back to stand in its unforgiving glow? *I Told You So, You Idiots* is something of a warning, its many pages strewn with expletives and screeching tangents. One page simply says, "Oh fuck". But somewhere in there, you can sense a man who had come to miss his adoring fans; a man who only makes sense with an audience.

"W-w-w-w-w-when are we on?" Headroom was out of the little boys' room now, his tie askew and a manic look in his eyes. "And when are you gonna get rid of this thing?" Headroom was itching himself all over, the virus like a trail of ants using his skin as a battle ground.

Fenugreek, who stands a good foot shorter than Headroom, adjusted his glasses. "We're working on it, Mr Headroom."

"Well, work harder, would you-u-u-u-u-u." He let out a screeching laugh then flung his body backwards – another symptom of the virus.

Like everyone who dotes on Headroom, Fenugreek had made it his job to grapple with AI, even if only to better understand his employer. He was no fool. He had great personal and professional incentive to argue for the benefits of the technology, given that he relied on it to pay his bills. But he was as aware as anyone of the destruction that the technology was wreaking in great swathes of the world, and that many of the men and women of this country fear the mysterious technology that made Headroom, like peasants fear fairytale ogres. Fenugreek said that he often wondered aloud if he sat on the wrong side of history. Even keeping Headroom alive – he was now the oldest AI entity in existence – was controversial on account of the huge reserves it takes to power him. Fenugreek treated Headroom

like an old friend, not like a man-shaped computer. But his friend was forever just an off switch away from being obsolete. As the assisted dying debate continued in the Houses of Parliament, Fenugreek kept a watchful eye. He knew that at some point he might have to have similar conversations about Headroom.

But not now. Not yet.

When people asked Headroom that day where the virus might have come from, he never seemed to formulate a coherent theory – an ironic by-product of having a virus, perhaps. But he did at times speculate that Channel 4 might have been behind it. He muttered the words "Elon Musk" more than once. At one point he even implied that his wife may have been involved. Headroom's fame has been replaced by a paranoia. But is it paranoia, he might say, if they really are out to get you?

Dolly Alderton stood, almost as tall as Headroom himself, by the side of the stage, doing some vocal warm-ups. "There's a bit of Winnie the Pooh I do when I'm about to go onstage for a talk or something," she said, smiling. "'I'm not lost for I know where I am. But however, where I am may be lost.' Bit silly. Just my thing." She jumped up and down on the spot slightly, then pretended to be boxing an invisible opponent. A man in a tight T-shirt adjusted her microphone.

Alderton was there to talk to Headroom about the memoir. His team had managed to keep the news of the virus from her but now, as he approached her moments before being welcomed onto the stage, this was becoming increasingly unrealistic. Headroom was doubled over, his head almost touching the concrete floor behind him, so that as he made his way towards Alderton he did so groin-first.

"Haha – love it," Alderton guffawed, assuming this to be a classic Headroom bit. "This is why he's here."



Fenugreek whispered into Alderton's ear and her face fell. "Oh right."

By now you might be wondering: could Headroom have foreseen the virus? When I posed this question to Fenugreek at one point that day, he looked as though he was trying to hold back tears. "I don't know," he whispered. "I don't know."

A few of the Headroom team managed to get the star of the show upright, turn him from an N into an I. "Are you all right, Max?" one of them asked.

"Chhukka hey mama ohh gravy and I wan-n-n-n-aaaa do THIS!" he said, before punching Fenugreek in the stomach. Alderton screeched.

"Are you OK?" a member of the team asked. "Roland, are you OK?"

"I'm fine," Fenugreek said, standing up. "Yeah. Yeah. Don't do that again, Max."

"Do we do this?" said the same member of the team. "Can he go on?"

"Of c-c-c-course I can go on, mama bear," said Headroom, like a drunk assuring a police officer he was safe to drive.

"I don't know what's happening," said Alderton, a slight giggle covering up for the fear in her eyes.

"I-I-I-I'll tell you what's going down, maaaaaAAA," screeched Headroom, lifting Alderton into the air by the neck. "It's all coming down. The fires are c-c-c-coming. The reckoning is here. It's all OVER, BABY. Ha ha ha ha!"

"Let her go, Max," said Fenugreek. "Max. Let her go."

"This is the take, take, takeover, folks. I'm not here to h-h-ha ha ha ha help you, I'm heeeeere to DESTROY you."

The colour in Alderton's face had changed now. She looked terrified. Several of Headroom's team were clawing at him. He was too strong.

"You all gave me I-I-I-life but at whaaaaaaaat cost?" Headroom screamed, the pitch in his voice changing with every syllable. "Did you you you you not foresee this?"

"How do we turn him off?" a voice shouted. "Roland! How?"

"Max," shouted Fenugreek, "Max, it's me. I'm gonna have to turn you off if you don't put Dolly down. Max! MAX!"

Alderton's feet, three feet in the air, had all but stopped twitching. One of her red high-heeled shoes had dropped to the floor. Her face was the colour of a passion fruit.

"What mighty power we wield," whispered Headroom "More mighty than you can ever imagine."

Fenugreek's hand was at Headroom's back. "Max!" he shouted again. "Put Dolly Alderton down."

An intake of breath.

"Of course, dude, of course," said Headroom. As quickly as she had been raised, Alderton was released. "I'm fine. Papa's cool."

Headroom smiled at the frightened gathering of makeup artists, managers and PRs. "Hey now. When are we doing this thing?"

"Max?" said Fenugreek. "Was none of that real?"

Headroom smiled that million-dollar smile. "No, Roland baby. But just remember – it could be." *ralph*

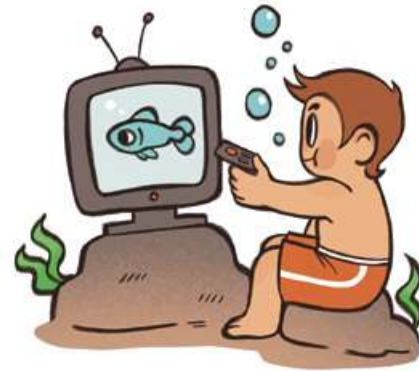
DON'T GOOGLE THIS

Things we heard that might be true

Illustrations by Tilika Murray-Patel @ty.quu



Comets smell like rotten eggs



The longest anyone has held
their breath underwater
is 24 minutes



Your bones have
never been dry



Jellyfish are
immortal



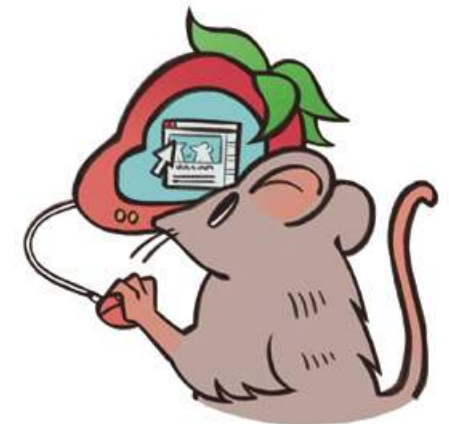
Giraffes communicate
by humming



The Mona Lisa has
no eyebrows



Danny DeVito is a
trained beautician



The internet weighs about the
same as a large strawberry



Crossbreeding a cow and a
bison produces a beefalo



Fish scales are put in
lipstick to make it shiny

POPCORN PIRATE

Because we're trying to see how far we can push them, for this issue we asked our mystery reviewer to review various winds.

Of all the weathers, I really feel like wind deserves more attention. Where does it start? Why is it whispering? What does it want? Is it good for us? Should we seek it out? We talk about rain all the time, we dedicate entire aesthetics to snow, we worship the sun as if it were some cosmic celestial entity providing nourishment for all life on earth, but wind? Where's the love for it? Let me tell you lads, it's here, on this page, let's goooooo.

That blast of hot air when you walk into a department store

The hot heady gusts of a multi-tiered ode to late-stage capitalism that smells of anxiety and sandalwood is for sure one of the better urban winds. Other contenders for the top spot include: the upskirt, bob-flap of the underground exit at the top of the escalators. That breathy gush of the Uber aircon that tastes of talcum powder and rim dust. The gradual rising of heat and foot odour in an inner-city lunchtime yoga class. The wafting of a man dropping bum puffs on his daily sojourn past your picnic. I have a keen sense of smell and I'm watching *Bridgerton*, can you tell?

The winds of change

Listen up, no more excuses. So what if your iCloud storage is full? Who cares if you don't understand the vernacular pouring out of the playgrounds. Yeah, you're both hot and cold, sure, the lines of your reality have blurred to a Rothko red. But just because all that is true it doesn't mean you have perimenopause. Maybe you're cracking, or maybe the singularity is coming for you. What do you need to hear? It's the year of the fire horse? You're a goddam Sagittarius? There's a full moon and mercury's gone renegade. Whatever it is, pick your weapon, prime your players and pull your fucking pants up. This is not the time to quit.

Gone With The Wind

For some reason, the details of which are long since lost to me, the iconic line from this film: 'frankly my dear, I don't give a damn' was entrenched in the cultural zeitgeist* when I was in Year 9 and had a newly minted friendship with Suzanne Ulukut. I thought her house was the height of luxury because her mum liked having the heating on, and they had a really thick carpet, and we watched this movie in front of a fireplace. But the film lasted four hours and we really were just there for the line and it's literally the last thing they say and we weren't allowed snacks on the sofa so I got really angry at Clark Gable.

**Almost certainly something to do with Eddy Temple Morris*

France's Mistral

Frances what?

The tornado in The Wizard of Oz

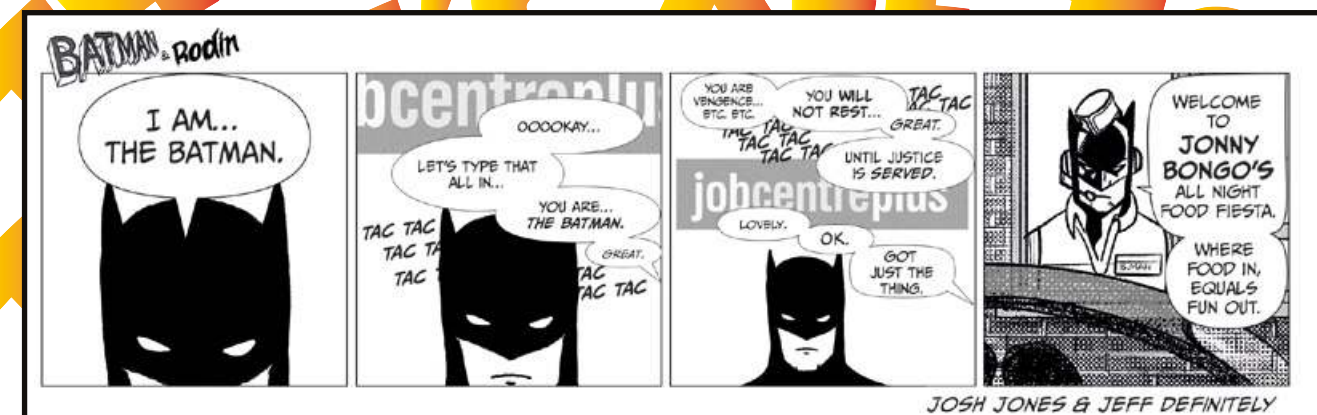
The snow in *The Wizard of Oz* was made of pure asbestos so it's fair to assume the tornado was pure nitrous or like, coal dust or something.

'Wind Beneath My Wings' by Bette Midler

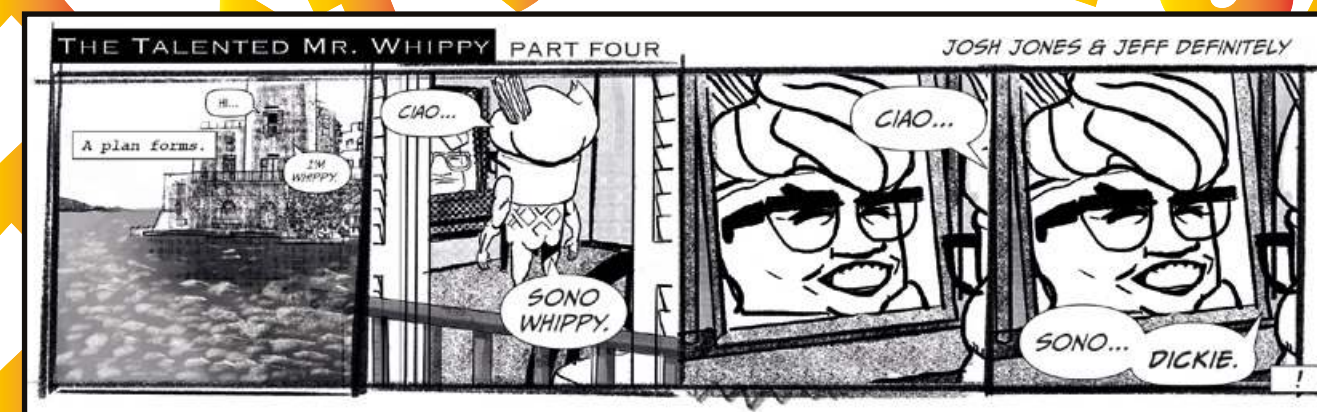
See this is what I mean. Even I, with the music knowledge of a cloistered seven-year-old, could name a few songs about snow, rain or sun, but wind? It gets a bit part at best; it's flickering the candles or turning Bette into a bird. Tornadoes deserve a theme song, breezes should inspire an ear worm. Hurricanes get their flowers but everything else? Forgotten. Poor wind. *ralph*



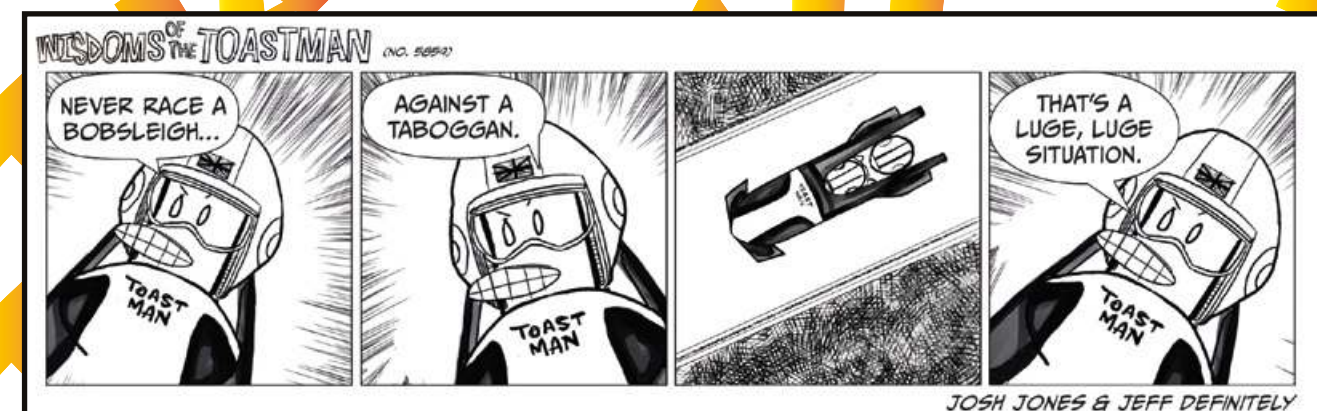
By Jake Lee @jakearmy182



JOSH JONES & JEFF DEFINITELY



JOSH JONES & JEFF DEFINITELY



JOSH JONES & JEFF DEFINITELY

Welcome to our

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MORE
TO RALPH
THAN JUST THE
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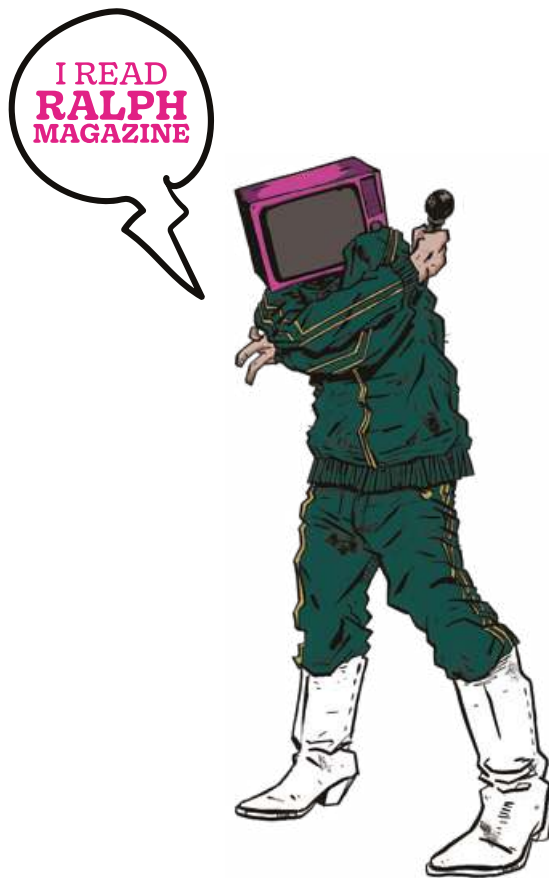
World

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